

VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

The Cistern

a novel



THE VÉSPERA LIBRARY · VI

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The Cistern

a novel of Véspera



VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

This is a work of fiction. Véspera, its houses and its people are imagined, and any resemblance to real persons is the resemblance true stories bear to one another. This novel has a self-knowledge sibling: if Soledade hurts you in real places, the name of what she carries is in “The Woman Who Never Asks”, in the SyncHim collection. A story understands, but it does not replace care: in the deep matters, seek support. You deserve the same care you give.

CONTENTS

Contents

01 The cistern of her own

02 The night of the door

03 All is well

04 The smoke that is missing

05 The illness she organises

06 The Keeper of the register

07 The pride of not needing

08 Learning to ask

09 The relapse

10 At the foot of the stairs

11 The water from outside

12 Asking before despair

FROM THE REGISTER OF VÉSPERA

From the register of Véspera

In the register of the village, by the hand of the Keepers who passed through the book, is found:

Soledade — solitude — of the Highlanders, of the house up on the heights, the one with its own cistern, and the name was a sentence before it was a name.

They called her Soledade, solitude, and she fulfilled the name to the letter, making of solitude not a misfortune that fell on her, but a fortress she raised, a house high on the mountain, with water of her own, that never needed to come down to the square, to ask of the fountain, to depend on anyone, and that had in this, her whole life, her pride and her sentence.

The register keeps the houses, and what each one has, and who comes down to the square to ask. It does not say what night it was, in childhood, that taught a girl that to ask was not safe, nor the price of the dryness of one who never lets in the water from outside, nor what it costs a cistern to knock, at last, at a door. For that, books such as this one are needed.

CHAPTER ONE

The cistern of her own



In sixty years, Soledade had never once gone down to the fountain in the square, because she had her own water at home, and in that lay the greatest pride of her life: the house up on the heights of the Highlanders, with its cistern, that gathered the rainwater and the spring water and never needed to ask a single drop of anyone. And it was not only the water. There was, in the house on the heights, a whole way of living that was one long not-asking, and that came from so far back that no one in the village remembered ever having seen it begin; and whoever spoke Soledade's name said, straight after, without thinking, the one up on the heights, the one who suffices to herself, the one who does not come down. That was how the village

kept her in its mouth, and that was how she kept herself within, in a phrase of three words that was her house and her prison at once: I do not need.

It was a winter morning, and Soledade, at sixty, was splitting firewood in the yard. She set the block, raised the axe above her head, let it fall, and the log split in two, and she set another, and another, with a rhythm she had kept for forty years, alone, in the cold, her breath smoking from her mouth. Her back ached, and the axe weighed on her more than it once had, and there was a pain in her shoulder that would not pass; but Soledade split the wood all the same, because firewood does not split itself, and there was no one else in the house on the heights to split it, and to ask a neighbour to split it for her was a thing that had never crossed her mind, or that had crossed it and that she had shooed away as one shoos away a fly.

She did everything like that, alone, and always had. She cut the wood, tended the garden, mended the roof when a tile fell, carried the sacks, kept the house, and never, in anything, asked a hand of anyone. When help was offered, she refused it. Once,

years before, a younger neighbour, Felisberto, of the house by the mill, seeing her carry a sack of potatoes up the slope, stopped his cart on the road and offered.

"Here, Soledade, let me take it for you on the cart, since I'm going up anyway."

"Thank you, Felisberto. There's no need. I'll carry it."

"But woman, that must be a good thirty kilos, and the climb is what it is."

"I'll carry it, I'll carry it. You go about your business."

And she carried it, the sack on her back, up the slope, slowly, with Felisberto behind in the cart, at her pace, not understanding why a woman of that age would refuse a lift that fell to her from heaven; and he went off shaking his head, and reached the mill and told his wife, Custódia of the Aurora line, who still remembers it, told her that Soledade of the heights was of a stubbornness that grieved a man, that she would sooner burst with the sack on her back than put it on the cart that was going up empty. And Felisberto's wife only said, that's not stubbornness, man, that's something else, that's a woman who has something twisted up inside her about asking. I'll do it. It was the phrase of

her life. I'll do it, I'll carry it, I'll see to it, there's no need, I'll manage. She said it to anything that was help, with a courtesy that was firm but whole, and she did it, however much it cost her, however old she was, however little her body would give, because asking, for Soledade, was the one thing she did not know how to do, or that she knew she did not do, for an old reason that lay at the bottom of her like the water at the bottom of the cistern, gathered and shut away for fifty years.

The stubbornness came to her from far back, and it showed itself in small things, the kind no one notices but that go on making the person. There was a ladder in the storeroom, long and old, with a rung halfway up that wobbled, and Soledade climbed it to clear the gutter of the chimney, in autumn, when the leaves blocked the spout; and each time she climbed onto that wobbling rung, alone on the roof, with the whole serra round about and no one below to hold the ladder, it crossed her mind, in a flash, that if she fell from there no one would know, and that she must take care, and she gripped tighter, and went on, and never, not for a shadow of a thought, did it occur to her to call someone to hold the ladder. To hold the ladder for one who climbs is the oldest and simplest thing one neighbour does for another in Véspera; it is asked from one window to the next, ho there, the

house, come and hold this for me a moment, and the other comes, and stands below with a hand on the ladder, and they talk while the work goes on up above, and it is in those small securings that the web that holds a whole village together is made, without anyone noticing. Soledade had never asked anyone to hold her ladder. She climbed alone a ladder that wobbled, and in that, too, she had her silent pride: that of needing neither a hand below, nor a pair of eyes to see her climb.

And the village respected her for it, and admired her. That one is made of iron, they said. That one needs no one. That one, at sixty, does what many young ones do not. That one suffices to herself. And Soledade, when such things reached her ears, liked to hear them, because sufficing to herself was her pride, was what she was, the one who does not need, the cistern that has its own water and does not come down to the fountain. Each time she refused a help, said I'll do it, carried alone what another would have asked to be carried for her, she felt a deep satisfaction, that of owing nothing to anyone, of sufficing to herself, of being independent like the house on the heights, with its own water, with no need of the square.

But there was, beneath that pride, a thing that Soledade did not say, and that was the reverse of it. The house on the heights, with its cistern, did not need the fountain, it is true; but it was also far from the fountain. Far from the square, far from the gathering of the village around the water, far from the talk that is made where people cross paths filling the pitcher, far from life. And Soledade, in the house on the heights, sufficing to herself, was also alone, set apart, outside. The independence that was her pride was also her isolation, because whoever does not need the fountain does not go to the fountain, and whoever does not go to the fountain meets no one; and the cistern of her own, that spared her the going down, spared her also the meeting. Down below, in the square, the women of the village filled their pitchers and talked, and laughed, and helped one another set the pitcher on the head, and knew of one another; and Soledade, up above, with her own water, knew of no one, and no one knew of her, and she called that being free.

Her husband had died young, more than thirty years before, in an accident at the quarry. His name was Alfredo, and he was a big, quiet man, of those who work the stone, and he had died as the men of the stone die, beneath it, in the collapse of a face that gave way one rainy morning. Soledade was then in her twenties,

and Domingos was a child on all fours, and she was in the kitchen making the broth when they knocked at the door in the middle of the morning, at the wrong hour, and she knew, before opening it, by the wrong hour of the knock, that it was misfortune, because knocks have their hours, and the one that morning had the hour of no good news. It was the quarry foreman, cap in hand, and behind him two men, and the foreman said only, Soledade, and said no more, because there was no need, and she stood at the door with the broth ladle still in her hand, and what came into her head, the first thing, was not the grief, for that came after and stayed; the first thing was a cold reckoning, the question of one who is left alone, and now, and the boy, and the house, and who, and the reckoning gave at once, in that instant at the door, the answer that was to govern thirty years: me. Now it is me. I'll see to it. I'll do it.

They brought him to her at the end of the afternoon, and the village came, as the village comes, the women filling the kitchen with food that no one ate and the men standing in the yard with their hats in their hands; and there came those who had to come, the gossips, the neighbour women, people offering themselves, Soledade, what do you need, count on us, don't be left alone with this. And Soledade thanked them all, dry-eyed, and

said the same thing to all, thank you, I'll manage, go easy, and she went on burying her husband and dispatching the condolences with a firmness that the village took for strength and that was already the cistern closing for good over her widowhood. There was one woman, old Benvinda, the mother of the one who stands today at the counter of the grocer's, who stayed to the last, and who at the door, on leaving, took her by both hands and said, look, my girl, I know what it is, for I too was widowed young, and I'll tell you one thing: don't do this alone. No one bears a whole serra on her shoulders, and you will want to bear it, for I see it in your face. Let the village help you. That is what it is for. And Soledade listened, and thanked her, and did not let her. She thought Benvinda said it out of an old woman's kindness, and that she herself was young and had arms, and that the village that helped today charged tomorrow, that all help is paid for, and that she owed nothing to anyone and did not want to begin owing in the hour when she was weakest. And she shut the door behind the last visitor, and was left alone in the kitchen with the boy asleep and her husband in the earth, and it was that night, more than the night of the FONSECAS' door, that the cistern finished turning itself to stone; because a woman who is widowed young, with a child to raise and a house to hold on the

serra, either asks and depends, or sets her teeth and does everything alone; and Soledade, who since she was a girl had sworn not to ask, set her teeth, and raised her son alone, and kept the house alone, and the village, seeing her, instead of helping her, admired her, that widow is made of iron, she raises her son alone and never complains.

And Domingos grew up watching his mother do everything alone, hearing her say I'll do it, never seeing her ask anything of anyone; and he learned, without anyone teaching him, that his mother needed nothing, that his mother sufficed to herself, and he carried that lesson into life, and it was for that reason, in part, that he could emigrate without remorse, because a mother who needs nothing is a mother one can leave alone on the serra without carrying the weight of leaving her.

The only tie was the son. Domingos, emigrated, far away, on the other side of a border, who telephoned on Sundays. And even him Soledade did not let in.

"So, Mother, how are you?" Domingos would ask. "Is everything all right there?"

"Everything's all right, son," Soledade would answer. "Don't you worry. Everything's fine."

"Do you need anything? Shall I send something?"

"I don't need anything. Get on with your life, that I manage here."

And Domingos, far off, set at ease by the everything's all right, did not press, because his mother had always been that way, made of iron, of not needing, and he had grown up hearing her say I'll do it, and had grown used to a mother who did not ask. And so he did not see, from afar, that the everything's all right was the greatest lie of the house on the heights, the lie Soledade told to everyone, to her son, to the village, the lie of sufficing to oneself, that hid a woman who needed, like everyone, and who had decided, fifty years before, one night, never again to let it be known.

There was a spot on the path, halfway down, at a bend in the track, from which one could see the square below and the fountain in the middle of it. Soledade passed by there when she went down to the village to see to what she had to see to, the papers, the market, the Mass that she went to seldom, and from the bend of the path she would see, without stopping, for stopping

to look was a thing she did not do, she would see the women around the fountain. It was in the morning, almost always, that being the hour of the water, and there were half a dozen of them, with their pitchers, and the water running from the stone spout into the trough, and them waiting their turn, and talking. They talked loudly, for the water covered the voices and it was necessary to speak over it, and they laughed, and Soledade, from up on the path, heard the laughter rise, ragged on the wind, without knowing at what. She saw Mariana of the Reis line helping old Encarnação set the pitcher on her head, with that knack that is an art, the roll of cloth coiled on the crown and the pitcher balanced on top without a hand to hold it, and the old woman setting off already upright with the water on her head and her whole body in one line, and Mariana calling after her something that made her laugh. She saw Aurora, sometimes, who went to the fountain too, though she had a well, because one went to the fountain also for the going, for the being there, for the knowing of the others. And Soledade would stand a moment at the bend of the path, with her empty pitcher that she had no need to fill because she had her cistern at home, looking at all that below as one who looks at a feast from a closed window: from outside, from above, without the sound, without mix-

ing in. And what she felt, if she stopped to feel it, which she did not, was a strange thing, half pride and half something else without a name, the pride of not having to go down there to queue for water, and beneath it, hidden, a lack, that of no one ever having set the pitcher on her head, that of never having laughed over the noise of the water, that of always passing at the bend of the path with an empty pitcher and going on up, to her own water, to her own house, to her solitude with the name of a house that suffices to itself. And she went on. She always went on up, and told herself within that she was free, and the fountain was left at her back, full of people, running.

And there came a night, at the start of winter, on which the cistern gave the first sign that it might run dry.

Soledade was alone in the house on the heights, after supper, mending a shirt by the lamplight, with the fire already low in the hearth and the silence of the serra coming in through the cracks, when she felt her chest tighten. It came slowly, at first, a clenching, like a fist closed inside her chest; and then a pain that rose up her left arm, from shoulder to elbow, and a shortness of breath, as if the room had all at once lost its air, and a cold sweat breaking out on her forehead and her lip, and her heart beating

out of time, leaping and stopping and leaping. She laid the shirt in her lap, and the needle fell from her hand and hung from the thread, and she sat still in the chair, very upright, with her hand on her chest, waiting, with the coldness of one who has seen people die and knows what this may be. The pain clenched harder, and Soledade thought, without alarm, with a strange clarity, it is the heart, I may be dying here, in this chair, this night.

And she looked at the telephone, on top of the dresser, three steps from her, the black telephone on its cord with which she spoke to her son on Sundays, and for an instant her right hand, the one that did not hurt, lifted from the chair and meant to go to it, to call someone, Aurora halfway down the slope, the health centre, the bus, whoever it might be, to say come, I'm ill, help me. And the hand stayed in the air, halfway to the telephone, trembling. And it did not go. It came down again, settled again in her lap, beside the shirt, because to call was to ask, and she did not ask, not even dying. She thought, in the chair, with the pain clenching, that if she called Aurora she would have to say I'm ill, come, and that Aurora would come, by night, up the slope, and find her there with the shirt in her lap, at her mercy, in need, and that this, to be found at her mercy, was worse, at

the bottom of her, than death itself; and she stayed in the chair, alone, with the pain, waiting for it to pass or to carry her off, and she called no one, because in the house on the heights, at that hour, with the door shut and the cistern full and no one to ask, Soledade preferred to risk dying alone to doing the thing she had sworn, fifty years before, never to do again.

The pain passed, after some minutes that seemed to her an hour. Soledade sat breathing, slowly, feeling her heart slacken, and when she had recovered herself, and the house returned to silence, a fright stayed with her, and the fright left her a question, the first of many: and what if one day it does not pass? And what if one day I fall, here, alone, and the pain does not pass, and there is no one, because I never let anyone in? Who notices me, in the house on the heights, with the door shut? How long do I lie here, fallen, before anyone marks that there is no smoke from my chimney?

And Soledade, with the question, did not change at once, for a cistern of fifty years is not changed in a night. But the question stayed, dripping, at the bottom of her, and it was the first drop of a new water: the suspicion that the sufficing to herself, which had been her pride all her life, might be, in the end, her sen-

tence. The sentence of dying alone in the house on the heights, of dryness, for never having learned the one thing the cistern lacked, the one thing that could save it from running dry: to let in the water from outside, which is, in people, to ask.

CHAPTER TWO

The night of the door



Soledade decided never to ask again on one night, as a child, and the decision lasted fifty years, and it was because of a door that did not open. Because there are doors that do not open in childhood and that close forever within a person, and she spends her life behind them, on the inside, without knocking at another.

She was eight years old, or nine, and it was a winter night, one of the frosty ones, on which her father fell ill all at once. He burned with fever, raved, and the mother, alone with her children in the house on the heights, understood, with the terror of the mothers of poor houses, that the man would go if the doctor did not come, and that the doctor was in the larger town, far away, and that to go and fetch him a mount was needed, and they had none. The FONSECAS had one. The FONSECAS, the rich house half-

way down the slope, had a horse, and had a servant, and had the means to send for the doctor in the middle of the night. And the mother, who could not leave the husband raving, looked at her children, and her eyes settled on Soledade, the eldest, the cleverest, the one who did not cry.

"Soledade," said the mother, and her voice trembled. "Go to the house of the FONSECAS. Knock at the door, and say that your father is dying, and beg them, for the love of God, to send the servant to fetch the doctor from the larger town. Run, child. Run, for your father does not wait."

And the child Soledade went down, in the dark, down the mountain, alone. It was deep night, and the cold cut, and the path was frosted, and she went barefoot, or near it, trembling, with the fear of the dark and the greater fear of her father dying, running down the track with her heart leaping. She fell once, skinned her knees, got up, went on. And she reached the house of the FONSECAS, the great house halfway down the slope, with its windows lit, for at that hour there was still light and movement inside, and she knocked at the door.

She knocked, and waited. And no one came. She knocked again, harder, with her small hand aching against the wood, and called.

"Ho there, the house! Senhor Fonseca! It's me, Soledade, of the Highlanders, from up above! My father is dying, I beg you for the love of God to send for the doctor! Ho there, the house!"

And on the inside there was light. There were people. Voices could be heard, and the scraping of a chair, and Soledade knew, with the terrible certainty of children, that they were there, that they heard her, that they knew who knocked and what she asked. And the door did not open. Instead of opening, the house fell silent. The voices dropped. And then, through the crack of the door, Soledade saw the light of the entrance go out, slowly, like one who blows out a candle to pretend not to be there; and the house of the FONSECAS made itself empty, dark, deaf, with the child at the door in the cold knocking and calling, and it did not open.

Soledade stayed there a long time. She knocked, and called, and wept, and knocked more, and the door did not open, and the light did not return, and the house stayed shut, pretending to sleep, while a child at the door begged help for a dying father.

And it was at that closed door, on that frosty night, that the child Soledade learned, once and for all, with all the terrible clarity of eight years, the thing that governed her life: that she had asked, that she had exposed herself, that she had put herself in another's hand, in the humiliation of knocking and calling and saying my father is dying; and that the other had heard her, and seen her small, and at his mercy, and in need, and had shut the door in her face, and put out the light so as not to see her. That to ask was this: to expose oneself for nothing. To humble oneself only to be met with the closed door. To be left at the mercy of one who could, simply, not open, and put out the light, and pretend not to be there.

And the child went back up, in the dark, alone, up the mountain, with skinned knees and the closed door at her back and the help unfetched. And on that climb, weeping with rage and cold and shame, she decided a thing, without words, with her whole body, with her whole wound: never again. Never again would she ask. Never again would she expose herself to that, to the knocking, to the needing, to the door that does not open, to the light that goes out. She would do everything alone, from there

on, cost what it might, so as never again to have to go down in the dark to ask, so as never again to be left at anyone's door with the request in her mouth and the door in her face.

The father, that night, did not die; he was saved another way, by a neighbour who at daybreak went himself to fetch the doctor. It was Anacleto, the old miller, who was on his way to the mill with the stars still in the sky and heard Soledade's mother crying out from the door to the road, and who had no horse but had his legs and had his donkey, and who harnessed the donkey there in haste and went himself to the larger town, in the dark, to fetch the doctor, and came back with him over the frost when the sun had barely broken. And Soledade's father was saved, by a hair and by the fever that yielded to the morning, and lay weeks in bed, and recovered. And the curious thing, which the child Soledade noticed and never forgot, was the difference between the two houses. Anacleto, who had nothing, had given everything he had, the donkey and the night and his legs, without being asked nicely, only for having heard a cry; and the FONSECAS, who had everything, the horse and the servant and the plenty, had not given so much as the opening of a door. And the child, who was clever, might have drawn from there the right lesson, that there are those who open and those who do

not open, and that it is worth knocking because sometimes on the other side there is an Anacleto; but the wound drew the wrong lesson, because wounds always draw the wrong lesson, and what stayed with Soledade was not Anacleto's donkey that came, it was the FONSECAS' door that did not open, because pain weighs more on the scale of children than rescue, and a door shut in the face cries louder than ten doors that opened.

When the father rose, weeks later, still weak, he learned at last, from the mouths of others, that his daughter had gone to knock at the FONSECAS' door that night and that they had not opened to her; and the man, who was gentle, was quiet a while, and then called Soledade to him, by the side of the hearth, and the child thought he was going to scold her, or thank her, or both. But the father did neither one nor the other. He stretched out his big hand and laid it on her head, and said only, slowly, without looking at her, looking at the fire, a thing the child kept and that she understood the opposite of how he meant it: child, do not hold a grudge against those people, for the grudge spoils the one who holds it and not the one who caused it. It was good counsel, it was the counsel of a wise man, it was the counsel of one who wanted to spare his daughter the poison; but the child, at that age and with that wound, heard another thing, heard do

not knock again at the door of people like that, heard the world is theirs and does not open to us, heard expect nothing from anyone; and she held the grudge, of course she held it, and held it fifty years, deep down, with the shame, in the still water of the cistern that began to fill that night.

The child who had gone down to beg for help died a little at that door, and in her place the cistern began to be born. Because a child to whom a door is shut when she begs for help for a dying father learns that to ask is dangerous, that to need is to be at the mercy, that to depend is to risk the greatest humiliation there is; and so as not to feel it again, she shuts herself, makes herself of stone, decides never to need anyone again. And it was thus that there grew the cistern that Soledade became, the one that gathers everything of itself so as not to have to knock at any door, the one that would sooner run dry than risk again the light that goes out.

And there was a thing that Soledade did that night, on reaching the top, that was the first brick of the cistern: she did not tell. The mother, seeing her come in without the help, asked her, distressed, well, child, and the FONSECAS, are they coming?, and Soledade, eight years old, with skinned knees and the humilia-

tion still on her face, did not tell that the door had not opened, that the light had gone out, that they had left her at the door in the dark. She said only, with her voice trembling, they weren't there, Mother, the house was all dark. She lied, to spare the mother the shame of knowing that the rich folk of the serra had shut the door on a child with a dying father; and in lying, in swallowing the humiliation alone, in not sharing it even with her own mother, Soledade made, at eight years old, the gesture she would repeat for fifty: to keep the pain inside, not to let it out, not to ask even for the comfort of being heard. It was the first water the cistern gathered and shut away: the shame of that night, kept, never told, rotting at the bottom of her for fifty years, because there are pains that, untold, do not heal, but stay, and Soledade never told that one to anyone, not to her mother, not to her son, not to Aurora, until the end.

And from then on, the child who had sworn not to ask went on training the not-asking in small things, as one trains a muscle, until it grew stronger than her own will. At school there was a mistress, Dona Genoveva, severe and just, who gave a snack to those who brought none, a hunk of bread and a leftover of cheese kept in a round tin on top of the cupboard, and who asked, at eating time, who didn't bring any?, so as to serve them

without shaming them. And there were days on which Soledade had brought none, bad days when at home there had been nothing to fill her bundle, and the child, at eating time, with the hunger gnawing, heard Dona Genoveva ask who didn't bring any, and the others raise their hands without shame, and she did not raise hers. She stayed quiet in her place, pretending she had eaten, swallowing her spittle, looking at the round tin on top of the cupboard with a hunger that hurt her, and did not ask, did not raise her hand, did not say I didn't bring any, mistress, because to raise the hand was to ask, was to say to the whole class I have none, I need, and she preferred the hunger to the raised hand. And Dona Genoveva, who was no fool, noticed, and one day, at the end of lessons, called her, and instead of forcing her to ask, did better, broke the bread in two without asking her anything, and gave her half, and said, eat, Soledade, for I know you didn't bring any and I know you wouldn't ask even if it killed you; and the child ate, with her eyes on the floor, with the shame of having been seen in need greater than the hunger that fed her, and swore within, one more stone in the cistern, that never again would anyone catch her needing anything, not even half a loaf.

And there was the time of the ankle. Soledade twisted her foot leaping a wall, with other children, and the foot swelled, and she could not walk, and the others, who were good, offered to carry her on their backs, or to go and call people, or to support her; and she said no, I'll go, and went, on foot, limping, up the slope, the whole way, with the foot throbbing, with the children behind watching her, telling her let us help you, Soledade, and her saying no, there's no need, I'll go. She reached home white with pain, with the foot the size of a loaf, and the mother scolded her, and the child did not say that the others had offered to carry her and that she had refused; she let stand the impression that she had come alone because there had been no one, when the truth was that there had been hands to spare and it was she who had not wanted them. And so the woman went on being made within the child, stone by stone, refusal by refusal, the bread not asked for, the carrying not accepted, the ankle borne alone, until the cistern grew so high and so closed that not even Soledade herself knew that there was, at the bottom of her, a child at the door in the dark knocking and calling, and that all the rest, her whole life, was only that child fleeing that door.

And the house of the FONSECAS stayed there, halfway down the slope, her whole life, on Soledade's path, which she had to pass each time she went down to the village. The FONSECAS died off, and the house passed to the children, and to the grandchildren, and the people changed, but the door was the same, the door of dark wood with the iron knocker, and Soledade, each time she passed by it, whether at twenty, whether at forty, whether at sixty, felt, without wanting to, a tightening in her chest and a shiver down her back, and quickened her step, and turned her eyes from the door, like one who passes near a dog that once bit him. She never told anyone why. The village saw Soledade quicken her step in front of the FONSECAS' house and had no idea, and she herself, with time, had almost forgotten the right reason, was left only with the tightening, with the shiver, with the turning of the eyes, which is how very old wounds live within us, already without the story, only with the fear the story left. Once, as a grown woman, already married, the FONSECAS' granddaughter, who was young and knew nothing, crossed her on the path and gave her good day with a smile, and Soledade answered sideways, dry, and went on, and the girl was left looking at her, not understanding what she had done; and she had done nothing, the poor thing, she had not yet been born on the

night of the frost, but she was on the inside of that door, she was of the blood of that door, and Soledade could not give good day kindly to anyone of the blood of the door that had not opened.

And the worst, which Soledade only came to understand much later, is that that door, shut once, in childhood, she came to see in every door. Each time she could ask, as an adult, she saw, without realising it, the door of the FONSECAS, the light going out, the voices dropping; and so she did not ask, because to ask was, for her, forever, to go down in the dark and knock at a door that would put out the light and feign itself empty. It never occurred to her that there were doors that open, that most doors open, that that one, the FONSECAS', had been one, a misfortune, a cruelty of a rich house on a night, and not the law of all doors. The child did not know how to do that sum. She generalised the closed door to all doors. And the woman lived fifty years treating all doors as the one that did not open, and so never again knocked at any, and so ran dry.

And when Soledade, at sixty, with the pain in her chest and the fright of the empty house on the heights, began to suspect that the sufficing was going to kill her, it was to that night that she had, without meaning to, to return, because it is always to the

source that one has to return in order to understand the river. And on remembering the Fonsecas' door, the child in the dark, the light that went out, the decision she had taken climbing the mountain with skinned knees, she understood, for the first time in fifty years, that her dryness was not strength, it was wound; that she did not ask not for being strong, but for being afraid, the old fear of the door that does not open. And she understood that, if she wanted not to die a cistern, she was going to have to do the hardest thing she could imagine, harder than all the wood and all the weights of fifty years: she was going to have to go down again in the dark, and knock again at a door, and risk again that it would not open, in order to discover, if it opened, that not all doors are the one of the Fonsecas, and that she could, at last, at sixty, let in the water from outside.

CHAPTER THREE

All is well



All is well was the phrase with which Soledade shut the door on her son, and she said it with love, so as not to worry him, and it was, said with love, the phrase that most separated them, because between a mother and a son there is no greater distance than an all is well said over a not-well.

Domingos had emigrated young, made his life far away, married there, had his children there, and telephoned his mother on Sundays, faithfully, every week, at the same hour. And the conversation was almost always the same, and almost always short, because Soledade did not make talk. Not because she did not want the son; because to make talk was to open, and she did not open.

"So, Mother, is all well?" Domingos would ask.

"All's well, son."

"Your health, is it keeping up? Does nothing hurt you?"

"No, no. It goes along. At my age it's always something, but it's nothing."

"And do you need anything? Do you want me to come there, the next holidays?"

"You need nothing, son. Get on with your life, you have your family, your children. I manage here."

And it was always so. Domingos trying to enter, slowly, with the questions, and the mother shutting, slowly, with the all's wells. And at the end of the call Domingos would hang up reassured, because his mother had said all's well, and Soledade would stay in the house on the heights, alone, with the not-well she had not said. And the two were left further from one another, separated not by the kilometres, which were already many, but by the door she did not open.

Domingos had grown up that way, watching his mother need nothing. He remembered, as a grown man, a thing he would tell Idalina, his wife, far away, to explain to her what his mother was like. He was about seven, and it was winter, and his mother was coming up from the spring with the two buckets of water, one on each arm, the water spilling over at every step, and the boy, who watched her make that effort every day, decided, with that enormous seriousness of children when they resolve to be useful, that on that day it would be he who carried a bucket. He ran, all proud, give me one, Mother, I'll carry it, I'm big now; and he took the bucket with both hands, and the bucket was almost his own size, and he dragged it a few metres, spilling, straining, with his face red and his tongue out, happy to be helping. And the mother, who walked ahead, turned, and saw the boy dragging the bucket, and instead of leaving him to it, instead of letting him spill half of it and reach home with the other half and his soul full, said, leave it, son, leave that, you'll get yourself all wet and catch a cold, go and play, I'll do it; and she took the bucket from his hands, gently, with love, without a shadow of malice, and went on with the two buckets as always, and the boy stayed there in the path, with his hands empty and wet, watching her climb alone. And what stayed with Domingos from that day, and

from a hundred days like it, was not that his mother had spared him; it was the feeling, deep, silent, that had no words at the time but that stayed in his body, that his mother did not need him, that he was one too many, that his mother held up so well alone that a son was a luxury and not a necessity, and that the best thing he could do for his mother was not to get in the way, to go and play, not to weigh. And that feeling, of not being needed by his own mother, had been the silent wound of Domingos's childhood, as the Fonsecas' door had been his mother's; and the two of them, mother and son, each carried his own wound without knowing that the son's was the daughter of the mother's, that the mother, by asking nothing of the son in order to spare him, had taught him that he was not needed, and had hurt him without meaning to, with the very gesture by which she hurt herself. And so, when Domingos told her he wanted her to ask, it was not only pity for the mother alone; it was the child still within him, wanting, at last, to be needed by his mother, wanting to be necessary, wanting to enter by the door the mother had shut on him since he was born.

And Domingos did not see, from afar, what was happening, because the mother did not let him see. He did not see that the mother could no longer manage the wood. He did not see the

pain in the shoulder that would not pass. He did not know of the night when her heart had failed in the chair. He did not see that the house on the heights was more and more a danger for a woman of sixty alone. He saw none of that, because each time he asked, the mother said all's well, and Domingos believed it, because he wanted to believe it, because his mother's all's well freed him, soothed him, allowed him to make his life far away without the weight of a mother in need. And Soledade, without knowing it, by saying all's well so as not to weigh on the son, was also robbing the son of the possibility of helping her, of being near, of being truly a son; and condemning him, on the day the truth burst, to the remorse of not having known, which is the remorse the mothers who say all is well leave to the sons they said it to.

Because there was, in the all is well, a hidden cruelty Soledade did not see, dressed as kindness. She said all's well to spare her son, she thought; but in saying it she took from her son the truth, took from him the right to know, to decide, to come to the rescue. She made him live in a quiet lie that one day would come undone in a blow, with a telephone call from a neighbour, or worse. And the son, who deserved a mother who would tell him the truth, who would ask him when she needed, who would

let him be a son, had a mother who told him all's well and kept him outside, and who confused, as all cisterns confuse, sparing with keeping away, not weighing with not letting in.

And the calls had a choreography, always the same, that Soledade danced without noticing. There was a stool by the dresser, in the kitchen, where she sat to talk, because the telephone was on a cord and had its place; and when the telephone rang on Sunday, at the right hour, Soledade composed herself before answering, straightened her back, cleared her voice, like one who composes herself for the photograph, so that nothing of the tiredness should pass down the line. One Sunday, that winter, a basket of wet washing had fallen on her on the way up the stairs, and she had slipped catching it, and struck her shoulder on the corner of the step, the bad shoulder, the one that already hurt her, and she had sat for minutes on the step breathing with the pain blinding her; and it was that afternoon, with the shoulder burning under her blouse, that the telephone rang, and she composed herself, and sat on the stool, and answered, and to the so, Mother, is all well?, she answered, all's well, son, with her voice clear, without a thread of pain, while she could not raise her arm above her shoulder. And Domingos, on the other side, on the other side of the world, heard a mother whole,

at ease, made of iron, and hung up reassured, and went to have supper with Idalina and the children without knowing that his mother was at that instant arranging an arm she could not lift, alone, in the kitchen of the house on the heights, with the wet washing unhung because she no longer had the arm to hang it. This was the all is well, in its small mechanics: it was not one big lie, it was a thousand little lies, one per Sunday, each the size of a shoulder, each pushing the son a little further from the true mother and drawing him closer to the mother of iron she put on the telephone for him.

And there was a call, that winter, that hurt Soledade and that made her see a thing. Domingos, at the end of the usual conversation, of the usual all's well, was a moment quiet, and then said, with a different voice, with a grief that was not his custom:

"Mother, you always tell me all's well. Always. For thirty years I've asked you and you always say all's well. And I sometimes think, is it really? Or has my mother never, in thirty years, let me help in anything?" He drew a deep breath, on the other side of the world. "You never asked me for anything, Mother. Never. Not once in your life. And I wanted you to, you know? I wanted you to ask me for something. It pains me to be the son of a

mother who needs me for nothing. It makes me feel that I'm of no use to you, that I could not exist and it would be the same. You suffice to yourself so well that I, the son, am one too many."

And Soledade, on hearing the it pains me to be the son of a mother who needs me for nothing, fell silent, with the telephone pressed to her face, in the kitchen of the house on the heights. Because she had never thought of that. She had never seen that her not-needing, which she thought a gift she gave her son, was after all a door she shut on him. That the son, on the other side, did not feel spared; he felt dispensable, outside, with no place in the life of a mother who sufficed to herself. That she, by sufficing to herself, did to her son exactly what the Fonsecas' door had done to her: left him on the outside, at the door, with the will to help in his hand and the door shut.

And when she hung up, that Sunday, she sat a long time on the stool by the dresser, with the it pains me to be the son of a mother who needs me for nothing hammering inside her. And she rose, and went to the drawer of the chest in the bedroom, where she kept the few things she kept, and took from there a bundle of letters tied with a string, the letters Domingos had written her in the first years of the emigration, before there was

easy telephone, when one wrote letters. And she untied the string, and read them, sitting there on the edge of the bed, by the faint light, the letters of the son of twenty, far away, homesick; and she noticed, rereading them fifty years of cistern later, a thing she had not seen at the time. In nearly all of them, the young man asked whether the mother needed anything, whether she wanted him to send money, whether she was well, whether there was anything he could do from there; and in all of them, she remembered, she had answered the same, all's well, son, I need nothing, get on with your life. And she understood, with the yellow letters in her hands, that the son had been asking her, for thirty years, by letter and by telephone, the same thing, let me help, let me be your son, let me be needed by you; and that she had answered him, thirty years, always with the same door shut in his face, I need nothing. That the son had spent his life knocking at his mother's door begging to enter, and that the mother, the cistern, had done to him, without realising, for thirty years, exactly what the Fonsecas had done to her on one night: left him at the door, asking, with the light put out. And she tied the string again, with her hands trembling, and put the letters away, and stayed in the dark of the bedroom under-

standing that the Fonsecas' door had had, after all, descendants; that she had inherited it, and passed it to her son, and that the chain of shut doors, if she did not break it, would go on.

And she understood, with that call, a thing that began to open a chink in the cistern: that to ask was not only a weakness she refused to show. That to ask was also, she discovered, a gift one gives to those who love us. Because those who love us want to help, want to be needed, want to enter; and the person who never asks takes from those who love her the joy of helping her, and shuts the door in their face as it had been shut in hers as a child. And that she, by never asking her son, by always telling him all's well, was, without meaning to, doing to her son the thing that had most marked her life, shutting the door on him, putting out his light, leaving him on the outside saying to him I do not need you. And that perhaps to ask, which she had learned to see as the humiliation of one who exposes herself, was also, seen the other way round, the generosity of one who lets the other in; and that her son, by asking her to ask, was teaching her, without knowing it, on the other side of the world, the thing she had spent her life not knowing: that to let someone help us is a way of loving them.

CHAPTER FOUR

The smoke that is missing



It was Aurora, the neighbour of the half-slope, who noticed what Soledade hid, and she noticed it by the smoke, because there are things only one who looks from afar and with care sees; and Aurora's care was what began to pierce the cistern from outside, while the son pierced it from within.

Aurora lived on the half-slope, lower than the house on the heights, and from her kitchen window one could see, up there, against the serra, Soledade's house. Aurora had a morning ritual that was almost a prayer, though she did not call it that. She rose before the day broke, lit her fire, set the kettle, and while the water warmed she went to the kitchen window, wiped the misted glass with the sleeve of her jersey, and counted the smokes. That was how she said it, within: counting the smokes. She counted the one from the Reis house, down at the bottom,

and the one from Felisberto's house by the mill, and the one from old Encarnação's house, and last of all, the one that mattered to her most, the one of the heights, Soledade's, against the serra, far from everything. And when she saw them all, the threads of smoke rising straight in the cold air, one for each house, one for each life that had woken and lit its fire, Aurora was at ease, and went to drink her tea, because the village was in the world one more day. Soledade's smoke was the most important to count because it was the smoke of one who had no one else. The other houses had people, had those who would notice if one morning there was no smoke; the house on the heights had only Aurora's eye, down below, counting it every morning, without Soledade knowing. It was the only watch Soledade had, without knowing it: the eye of a neighbour who saw her smoke every morning, because the smoke was the only thing of Soledade's she could not hide, that rose from the chimney in sight of whoever cared to look.

And there was a thing Aurora did, that no one knew, and that shows the woman she was. On the days of thick fog, of the kind that cover the serra and let no house be seen, Aurora grew anxious, because she could not see the smokes, and not seeing the smokes was for her like being struck blind to the lives of her

neighbours; and on those days of white blindness she waited, and went back to the window hour by hour, waiting for the fog to ease and give her back the threads of smoke one by one; and when the fog at last lifted, and she saw the house on the heights reappear with its smoke, she sighed with relief like one who finds a person again. It was a way of loving the whole village, silent, from a window, that no one had asked of her and that no one thanked her for, because no one knew. Aurora was no cistern. Aurora was the opposite of the cistern; she was of those who bind themselves to others by invisible threads, by threads of smoke, and who carry, without show, the lives of their neighbours in the cradle of their eyes every morning.

And there was a morning, that winter, on which the smoke did not come.

Aurora looked, as she always looked, on setting the water to the fire, and the chimney of the heights was out, without smoke, and it was late already for that, for Soledade lit it early, before everyone. Aurora found it strange. She waited a while, went to see to her things, and looked again, and nothing, the chimney cold, without a thread of smoke. And her heart tightened, because a smoke that is missing in the house of an old woman

who lives alone means, many times, a misfortune. And Aurora, instead of doing what Soledade would do, which was not to meddle, to leave each to her own, put on her coat, and climbed the slope, with effort, for she too was no longer young, up to the house on the heights, to knock at the door, to see what it was. Because Aurora was no cistern; she was of those who notice the smoke that is missing and climb to see.

And well she did, for Soledade had fallen. It had not been grave, a dizziness on rising, a weakness, and she had slipped, and stayed on the kitchen floor, unable to get up well, with a pain in her hip. And she had been there for hours, on the cold floor, alone, without having lit the fire, without having called anyone. Because even fallen on the floor, even in need, even knowing that no one would come, Soledade had not called, had not dragged herself to the telephone, had not begged for help; she had borne it there, on the floor, waiting to gather strength to rise alone, because I'll do it, because to ask, no, even fallen, even with her hip aching, even past all hours.

Aurora knocked, and no answer came, and she knocked more, and called, oh Soledade, oh Soledade, is it you, are you there?, and heard, inside, faint, an I'm here, and pushed the door, which

was not bolted, and found the old woman on the kitchen floor, fallen, frozen, with the face of one who has been there a long time. And she came to her rescue. She lifted her, carefully, sat her up, lit the fire, made her a hot tea, wrapped her warm, stayed with her, and saw to her as Soledade would never let herself be seen to if she were on her feet to refuse it.

And Soledade, rescued by Aurora, felt two things at once, and the struggle between them was the book. She felt, first, the shame, the old humiliation, that of having been seen fallen, at the mercy, in need, which was exactly what she had spent her life avoiding, which was the Fonsecas' door in reverse: to be caught on the floor needing one who would lift her. And she wanted, with all the force of the cistern, to refuse, to say I'm well, there's no need, I'll get up alone, go away, Aurora, that I manage; and she almost said it. But she felt, beneath the shame, another thing, new, that disarmed her: she felt relief. The enormous, physical relief of not being alone on the floor, of having someone there, of being lifted by another person's hands, of not having to right herself alone one more time. And it was the first time in fifty years that Soledade felt the relief of being rescued, and it was so deep, and so unknown, that it left her confused, because all her life they had told her, and she had believed it,

that to need was humiliation; and there, fallen, rescued, she discovered that to need, and to let herself be rescued, was also, beneath the shame, a relief, a rest, almost a sweetness, that of not being alone.

Aurora stayed with her the whole afternoon, made her supper, helped her to bed, and on leaving, already with her coat on, stopped at the door, and said to her a simple thing that stayed with Soledade.

"Oh Soledade, I see your smoke every morning, down there, from my kitchen. It's my way of knowing you're well. Today there was no smoke, and I climbed." She gripped her shawl. "If one day you need it, don't wait for the fall. Light two fires, make two smokes, or put a white cloth at the window, arrange a sign with me, that I'll see it, and I'll climb. I won't leave you up there alone, woman. You live up on the heights, but you don't live alone in the world, do you hear? I'm down here, and I see your smoke." And she lowered her voice, and told, slowly: "I watch the smokes of the houses for a reason, Soledade. Years ago, a neighbour of mine died, Custódia, who lived alone, next to my mother, and she died at home, at night, and no one noticed, and only after three days, by the smell, was it known. Three days,

Soledade, a Christian soul dead alone at home three days, and the whole village passing the door without knowing. And I swore, that day, that while I had eyes, no neighbour of mine would die three days with no one noticing. That's why I watch the smokes. Yours, and others'. It's my way of not letting anyone die alone within my sight. Don't take that from me, woman. Let me see your smoke."

And Aurora, sitting there at the edge of Soledade's bed, with her shawl in her hands, told her the whole of Custódia, slowly, because it was a story she had carried for years and had seldom told. Custódia had been a woman like so many, a widow, without children, or with a son who had gone and not returned, which was never known for certain; and she lived in the little house leaning against Aurora's mother's, wall to wall, and she was of those who said good day over the wall and nothing more, of those who let no one in, of those who saw to their own lives and did not want theirs seen to. I knew her, Soledade, said Aurora, knew her a lifetime, and she was like you, forgive me for saying it, she was made of iron, did everything alone, and when my mother knocked at her door with a plate of broth, for my mother was like that, Custódia thanked her from the threshold and did not let her past the doorway, took the plate at the door

and shut it, and sent the plate back the next day, washed, with a thank you and nothing more. And she went on shutting herself up, and went on falling silent, and one winter she caught a cold that no one knew of because she told no one, and the cold turned into something else, and she took to her bed, and did not rise again, and died in bed, at night, alone, with the door bolted from within as she had always kept it.

And Aurora lowered her voice still further, and said the part that cost. And no one noticed her for three days, Soledade. Three days. The house silent, the chimney without smoke, and no one found it strange, do you know why? Because she had taught the whole village to find nothing strange about her. She had said all is well so many years, had sent back so many bowls of broth, had shut so many doors, that when she shut herself for good no one noticed the difference, because a door shut forever does not change its face when it begins to hide a dead woman. In that house, the shut door was the custom, and so death could hide itself in it three days in sight of everyone. And only on the third day, in the morning, it was the smell, Soledade, forgive me, it was the smell that came to my mother through the wall, and my mother knocked, and called, and nothing came, and they went for the men, and they broke down the door, and there she was.

And my mother, who had taken so many bowls of broth to that woman and had had so many sent back, was left with that clinging to her until she died, with the idea that her neighbour had died on the other side of a stone wall while she slept, and that it had not been for want of someone who wanted her, it had been for excess of shut door.

And it was there, Aurora told, at the edge of Custódia's grave, that I swore what I swore. I swore that while I had eyes no neighbour of mine would die three days with no one noticing. And that is why, Soledade, I began to count the smokes. It is not for being a busybody, woman. It is because of Custódia. It is so that never again, on my serra, shall there be a shut door hiding three days a Christian soul whom no one wanted to see die.

And Soledade, on hearing the story of Custódia, of the three days, of the smell through the wall, of the door that, from being forever shut, did not change its face to hide a dead woman, understood that Aurora did not watch her for being a busybody, but for love, for a silent love of one who had decided not to let the serra swallow anyone else in silence; and she understood, with a tightening that froze her more than the kitchen floor, that she herself, in the shut house on the heights, was exactly a can-

didate for the death of three days, a Custódia waiting to happen, with the same forever-shut door, with the same all is well taught to the village, with the same cistern; and that her house, if she did not change, was a house where death could hide three days without changing the face of the door, because the door was already shut, was already silent, had already taught everyone not to find anything strange; and that the only thing that would keep her from being Custódia was to let Aurora see her smoke, that is, to let someone in.

And Soledade lay in the bed, with her hip aching, with the I see your smoke, with the I won't leave you up there alone warming her more than the tea. And she understood, shaken, that after all she was not so alone as she thought. That there was, on the half-slope, a person who watched her smoke every morning, who cared, who had climbed the slope with effort to come to her rescue. And that her solitude, her cistern, her not-needing, were not so true as she believed, because there were people willing to enter, to come to her rescue, to watch her smoke; and that it was she, and only she, who did not let them, who shut the door, who said all's well, who refused. And that perhaps her solitude was not a misfortune that had fallen on her from

heaven, but a door she kept shut from within, and that on the other side there was, after all, those who wanted to enter, if she one day opened it.

And the next morning, recovered from the fall, Soledade did a small thing that showed the first water entering the cistern. She rose, with her hip still complaining, and the first thing she did, before the coffee, before anything, was to light the fire with care and go to the window to watch the smoke rise from the chimney. And she stood there, at the window, watching her own smoke rise straight in the cold air, and thinking, with a strange tenderness, that down below, on the half-slope, behind another window, Aurora would be watching that same smoke, and being set at ease, and saying within, she's well, Soledade's well, there's smoke on the heights. And Soledade, who all her life had lit the fire only to warm herself, lit it that morning also to be seen, to send Aurora, by the smoke, the word that she was in the world; and it was the first time in her life that she did a thing thinking that on the other side there were eyes that counted her, and instead of troubling her, that thought warmed her. And she understood that it was good, that it was one of the warmest things there is, to know oneself watched by someone who cares, to know that if one morning the smoke did not rise, someone

would notice, someone would climb the slope to see. And she stayed at the window longer than she needed, watching her smoke rise and imagining Aurora watching it from below, two smokes keeping each other company above the serra; and she felt, by that fine thread of smoke binding two windows, the first connection to the fountain she had refused for fifty years.

CHAPTER FIVE

The illness she organises



Soledade fell ill, in earnest this time, of an illness that asked for treatment, trips to the larger town, doctors, care; and Soledade did what a cistern does when it falls ill: she organised the illness so as not to have to ask, which is the most extreme form of not asking, to turn her own weakness into a work to be done alone.

It was the hip, from the fall, that would not heal, and there were other things that the doctor from outside, on seeing her, discovered, things that called for tests in the larger town, the right treatments, comings and goings. And for most people, to fall ill is the hour of asking, it is when even the most independent accept a hand, a lift, company, because the sick body compels. But Soledade, no. Soledade, on learning that she had to go to the

larger town, instead of telephoning Domingos to say son, I'm ill, come, or asking Aurora to take her, set about organising the illness alone, as she organised everything.

She studied the bus timetables. She calculated at what hour she had to leave to reach the appointment, and at what hour the return one was, and how to make the way from the health centre on foot, with her hip aching, with the cane. She arranged the tests for the days on which there was a bus. She found a way to do everything by herself, the old sick woman catching the bus alone to go and be treated, and returning alone, up the slope, to the house on the heights, and telling everyone, the son on the telephone, Aurora at the door, all's seen to, I manage, I need nothing.

And it was a spectacle of stubbornness that moved and revolted: the sick Soledade refusing that the illness should force her to ask. The body told her ask, you're ill, you can't alone; and she answered the body I'll do it, and did, exhausted, trembling, catching buses, making alone a way that no one ill should make alone, only so as not to ask, only so as not to owe, only to keep standing, even ill, even falling, the pride of the cistern that suffices to itself. There was in this a courage, yes; but it was a

courage turned inside out, a courage in the service of fear, the enormous courage a person spends so as not to do the small and terrifying thing that is to ask.

The bus to the larger town passed through the square at ten past seven in the morning, and Soledade, on the days of the appointments, had to leave the house on the heights still in the dark to catch it, go down the slope with her cane and her aching hip, wait in the square in the cold. And there was, on that bus, a woman who went almost always, Glória das Dores, of those of the half-slope, who went to the larger town to the doctors as she did, and who was the opposite of her in everything. Glória boarded the bus talking and left it talking, told her whole life to whoever sat beside her, and one day she sat beside Soledade, and told her, without anyone asking, that she was going to the heart doctor, and that it was her son-in-law who took her to the bus in the morning and came to fetch her in the afternoon, for she no longer saw well for the path from the square, poor thing, and that thank God she had her son-in-law, who was a saint, and her daughter, and the grandchildren who kept her company. And she asked Soledade, with the good curiosity of those who talk to everyone, and you, do you go to the doctors alone? Have you no one to take you? And Soledade said, I have the bus,

that takes me and brings me, I need no more; and Glória looked at her with a strangeness that had no malice, and said only, ai woman, I couldn't do it alone, if I didn't have my son-in-law waiting for me at the stop with the car I'd die of fright, for these doctor things, a person comes out dizzy and needs an arm. And Soledade fell silent, and looked out of the window at the serra going by, and within, though she did not say it, Glória pained her; not Glória, Glória's life, the son-in-law waiting at the stop, the arm at the doctor's door, the full house. Glória had all that and did not notice it, spoke of it as one speaks of the weather, and Soledade, who had none of it, understood on that bus, for the first time with clarity, that the difference between her and Glória was not that Glória needed and she did not; it was that Glória let herself be helped and she did not, and that for that reason Glória went to the doctor with a son-in-law waiting and she went alone, and that her independence, beside Glória's happy dependence, suddenly no longer seemed to her a richness, it seemed to her a poverty with a pretty name.

Domingos, on learning of the illness, wanted to come. He telephoned, distressed.

"Mother, I'll come there. I'll take leave, and come there, and take you to the doctors, and stay with you all that time."

"Don't come, son," said Soledade. "It's not worth it. All's seen to. I'm managing, the bus takes me and brings me. Get on with your life, you've your own there."

"But Mother..."

"Don't come, Domingos. I manage here."

And Domingos, from afar, unable to come by force, was left with the powerlessness of one who wants to help and is not let, with his mother ill refusing him entry; and he was hurt, and said to her on the telephone, in a voice Soledade did not forget:

"Mother, you're taking from me the one thing I can give you. I can't be near, I live far away, and it's a cross I carry, that of having my old mother alone on the other side of the world. And when there's one time, just one, when I could come, could be of use to you, could do something for you, you don't let me. Why, Mother? Why do you prefer to go ill, alone, on the bus, with the cane, to letting your son care for you? What did I do to you, Mother, for you not to let me help?"

And there was, at one of the appointments, a doctor who read her as the Keeper would read her later, though in another way. He was a doctor already advanced in years, of the old sort, who still received the old women of the serra and had known them a lifetime, Doctor Aníbal, and who, on examining her, on seeing the hip, the tests, the woman's tiredness, asked her, slowly, and do you live alone, Dona Soledade, do you not, up there on the heights? And Soledade said yes, and he was a moment looking at her over his spectacles, and said to her a thing she carried home crosswise. Look, I can treat your hip, and I will, and I can give you the pills, and I do. But what you have, most of it, I do not cure with any prescription, because what is wearing you out is not only the age, it is the doing everything alone in a house on the heights with no one. The body of a person of your age was not made to carry a serra alone, Dona Soledade. You need someone to help you, and that is not sold at the apothecary's. Have you family? And Soledade said, with the usual firmness, I have a son, but he lives far away, and the neighbour, but I manage, Doctor, I don't want to weigh on anyone; and Doctor Aníbal shook his head, slowly, and said only, well, that's always what the women of your stamp tell me, and they're the ones I see come back worse. And she did not understand, at the time, what

he meant by the women of your stamp, and was to understand later, with the Keeper: that there was a stamp of women, those of iron, those who did not ask, and that these were the ones the doctors saw come back worse, because they left everything for too late, because they organised the illness alone, because they reached the consulting room already fallen instead of reaching it in time; and that she was of that stamp, and that Doctor Aníbal had seen it at once, in the first appointment, by the way she had refused to be accompanied.

And the son's question, what did I do to you for you not to let me help, shook Soledade, because the answer was nothing. Domingos had done nothing to her. And yet she refused him. And she understood, with the question, that her refusal had nothing to do with the son; it had to do with the Fonsecas' door, with the night on which she had asked and they had not opened to her. That she was making the son pay for a door that had shut fifty years before. That she refused the son entry not for distrusting him, but for having learned, as a child, to distrust all doors; and that the son, who was a door that wanted to open, who offered himself, who asked to enter, was being treated by

her as the FONSECAS' door, shut out, refused, without understanding why, because the why was not his, it was of a frosty night of fifty years ago that she had never told him.

There was, in one of the treatments, a question that caught her off guard. The nurse, a young girl, in her twenties, in a white coat and with direct manners, on preparing her, on putting the needle in her arm for the drip, asked her, as one asks everyone, with her head bent over her arm, and who came to accompany you, Dona Soledade, who takes you home? And Soledade, who had come alone on the bus, was left without an answer. For an instant she thought of lying, of inventing a nephew waiting, an arranged lift, anything to cover the truth; but she was tired, and ill, and the drip entering her vein, and she had no strength for the lie, and she said the bare truth, I came alone, I go alone. And the nurse lifted her head from her arm, and looked at her, with that frank pity of the young who have not yet learned to hide pity, and said, ai you shouldn't do these things alone, have you no one? And that have you no one pained Soledade more than the treatment, because it was a question that set her before the truth she hid: that she had, yes, she had a son, she had a neighbour, she had a village, and that even so she came alone, because she did not ask, because she did not let. That the have you

no one was not true, and was; that she had people and was alone, which is the worst of solitudes, that of one who has and does not let herself be accompanied. She went home that day with the nurse's have you no one hammering, and with the shame of having lied without lying, of having let it be thought she had no one when what she had not was the courage to ask those she had.

And it was in that illness, organised alone with so much effort, that Soledade touched the bottom, and it was necessary to touch in order to turn. It was on a rainy day, on a return, at the end of the afternoon, after a treatment that had left her weaker than usual. The bus came almost empty, for it was the last one, and went slowly along the serra road, with the rain lashing the windows and the wipers screeching, and Soledade sat alone on a seat at the back, with her hip throbbing at every jolt, with her sight darkening from weakness, with a sickness rising in her. She leaned her head against the cold glass of the window, and the glass trembled with the engine, and outside the serra went by grey in the rain, the houses with their lights coming on, one by one, at the mouth of night, each light a family gathering at the table; and Soledade watched the lights go by, the houses of others coming on with people inside, and thought of her house

up on the heights, dark, waiting for her, with no light lit because there was no one there to light it before she arrived, and that she was going to arrive at night, with effort, up the slope, in the rain, and was going to enter a cold and dark house and light the lamp and the fire herself, alone, ill, as she had always done.

And it was watching the lights of the houses of others, in the rain, from the bus, that something gave way within her, something that had borne up fifty years and that on that afternoon, in her weakness, bore up no more. And she felt herself, for the first time in fifty years, not proud of her sufficing, but tired of it. Tired to the bone of doing everything alone. Tired of not asking. Tired of organising even the illness so as not to owe anything to anyone. And there came to her, in the midst of the tiredness, a new wish, almost a desire, that frightened her and that relieved her at the same time: the wish to ask. To stop. To let someone take her, someone care, Domingos come, Aurora accompany her. To rest, at last, from the sufficing. To set down the cistern.

And she understood, with that wish, that perhaps it was not weakness to want to be cared for; that perhaps it was the most human thing there is. And that she, by refusing it her whole life, had not been strong, had only been faithful to a shut door. And

that it was time, at last, ill, tired, leaning against a trembling bus window weak with faintness, to do the thing she had never done; and that her illness, perhaps, was the occasion to learn it: to ask, before the body forced her to ask in the worst way, fallen, without choice, late, as had nearly happened on the night of the pain in her chest and on the morning of the fall. To ask early, by choice, with dignity, instead of asking late, out of despair, with none.

CHAPTER SIX

The Keeper of the register



She went to see to some papers of the house on the heights at the House of the Register, alone like everything, with her cane, with her hip still aching; and it was thus, by one more thing she did without asking a hand, that Soledade found herself seated before the Keeper.

The House of the Register was cool, and smelled of paper and of wax, and the Keeper, a woman of a certain age, with spectacles on the tip of her nose, saw to the papers slowly, and went on noticing Soledade: the cane, the way she had refused help at the entrance, the manner of one who does everything alone, even what she can no longer do. And the Keeper, who saw people as she saw the houses, saw in the woman the cistern.

"Soledade lives in the house on the heights of the Highlanders, does she not?" she said, without lifting her face from the paper. "The one with its own cistern, of the few that do not need to come down to the fountain."

"I do," said Soledade, with pride. "And I have my own water. I never needed to come down to the square. The house on the heights always had its cistern."

The Keeper laid down her pen, and looked at her over her spectacles.

"And that is your pride, I know. But let me tell you a thing I have learned to see, in this book, over the years, in the houses of cistern and in the women of cistern, which are, after all, the same thing." She leaned back. "A cistern gathers the water of the rain and of the spring, and it is a good thing, it is plenty, it is independence, not to need to come down to the fountain. But the cistern has a danger the fountain does not have. The fountain comes from the serra, runs always, is living water, never runs dry, because it is connected to a vein of water that comes from far and does not stop. The cistern, no. The cistern has only the water it gathered, its own, shut in, still. And in a winter without rain, in a dry summer, the cistern, however deep, goes down, and down,

and if the drought lasts, it runs dry, because it is connected to nothing else, it has only what it gathered, and what is gathered runs out. The houses of cistern are the first to run dry in the great droughts, Soledade. Those of the fountain, never."

And Soledade heard this, and it went deep, because she understood that the Keeper was not speaking only of the water. And there came to her memory, on hearing of droughts, an old summer, the worst that was remembered on the serra, a summer in which it did not rain from May to October and in which the whole village trembled for the water. She remembered that, that summer, the cisterns went dry, one by one, the houses that boasted of having their own water saw it go down and down to the slime at the bottom, and had to come down to the square, pitcher in hand, to fetch from the village fountain the water their cisterns no longer gave, and it was a humiliation for the proud ones, who had boasted all their lives of not needing the fountain and who that summer went to the fountain like everyone. And the fountain, that one, at the worst of the summer, fell low, but did not run dry, because the fountain came from the deep vein of the serra, from the living water, and gave drink to the whole village, the houses of fountain and those of cistern, all drinking from the same stone spout that summer of drought.

And Soledade, who had her own deep cistern and who had borne that summer without coming down, remembered feeling, at the time, pride for it, I did not come down, my cistern gave; and she understood now, with the Keeper, that she had had luck, only that, that her cistern was deep but was not infinite, and that in a summer a little longer it would have run dry like the others, and she would have come down to the fountain like the others, or worse, she would have preferred to run dry than to come down. The image stayed with her: all the cisterns going down to the slime, and the fountain, alone, giving drink to everyone, because it was connected to the vein that does not run dry. And the Keeper, seeing that she understood, went on, more slowly:

"You are a cistern, Soledade. You gathered everything of yourself your whole life, sufficed to yourself, never asked, never came down to the fountain, never let in the water from outside, and you have in this your pride. But you are in a drought, now. In age, in illness, in the solitude of the house on the heights. Your cistern is going down, and there is nowhere for more water to come from, because you never connected yourself to any fountain, never let anyone in, never asked, and the water you gathered of yourself is running out." She tapped lightly on the

table. "And people, Soledade, were not made to be cisterns. They were made to be fountains, connected to one another, giving and receiving water, asking and rescuing, because that is how the water runs and no one runs dry. And you, by making yourself a cistern, by not asking, cut yourself off from the vein that connects people, and you are running dry alone in the house on the heights. Not for lack of water in the world, for there are fountains around you, your son, your neighbour Aurora, the whole village; but for never having opened a pipe that would let the water from outside into your cistern."

And the Keeper leafed through the book, slowly, and stopped at a page, and said the thing that most pained Soledade.

"And do you know what is, in my experience, the saddest thing that is written in this book? It is not poverty, nor illness, nor misfortune. It is the death of a cistern. It is when there comes to me the entry of a person who lived surrounded by people who would have helped her, who had children, neighbours, a village, and who died alone in her house, of dryness, not for there being no one to rescue her, but for never having asked, for having said all is well to the end, for having shut the door to all the water from outside. And the saddest, in the entry of those, is that on

the other side of the door they kept shut there was, almost always, people wanting to enter, people who would have given everything for an open door, and who stayed outside their whole lives, watching the cistern run dry without being able to pour it a drop, because the cistern would not let them." She looked at her, grave. "Do not die so, Soledade. You have a son who wants to enter, who asks it of you on the telephone. You have a neighbour who watches your smoke. Open a pipe. Ask. For to ask is not to come down defeated to the fountain; it is to connect your water to that of the others, so that none of you runs dry alone."

And the Keeper leafed through the book to a page, and turned it towards Soledade, and put her finger on an entry.

"Look at this one, Soledade, so you see I'm not speaking idly. Custódia, who lived next to Aurora's house. I knew her well. A woman like you, of iron, who did not ask, who sufficed to herself, who said all is well to whoever asked her. And she died alone at home, at night, and only after three days was it known, by the smell." She tapped lightly on the page. "This entry, Custódia's, is one of those it most cost me to write in forty years, because I had to put here the date of the death and the date on which it was known, and between one and the other go three

days, three days of a Christian soul dead with no one noticing, and not for there being no people who wanted her, for there were, Aurora, the village; it was for her never having let anyone in, for having shut the door her whole life, like you." She looked Soledade in the eyes. "I do not want to write your entry as I wrote Custódia's, Soledade. I do not want to put a date of death and another of when it was known, with three days in between. I want to put a single one, with people around. But that depends on you, on your opening the door while there is still time."

And Soledade looked at Custódia's entry, the old woman of iron who had died alone three days, and shivered, because it was her own future written there, in the shut house on the heights, if she did not change.

And the Keeper, seeing her shiver, and because she was a woman not to leave a person alone with fear, leafed back through the book, slowly, in search of something else, and stopped at another page, older, and put her finger on another entry.

"But I'll not show you only Custódia's, Soledade, for that would be to leave you in the dark, and I am not the Fonsecas. Look at this one. Felismina, of the house by the oven, whom you did not

know, who was before your time. This one too was of iron, widowed young like you, with three children, and she too had sworn not to ask. But Felismina, one day, in a bad winter, in a year of hunger, reached the end of her strength, and instead of shutting herself and running dry, did the opposite, came down to the square, to the fountain, and said to the village, loud and clear, in front of everyone, that she had nothing to feed her children and that she begged help. There were those who said it was a shame, that a respectable woman does not beg in public; but the village, deep down, which is better than its evil tongues, gathered around her, and whoever had wheat gave wheat, and whoever had oil gave oil, and Felismina's children got through the winter, and grew, and became somebody, and one of them to this day sends money to the village at Christmas, in memory of the winter in which his mother asked and the village came to the rescue. And when I wrote Felismina's entry, at the end of a long life, Soledade, I could put a single date, a date of death and people around, the three children and the grandchildren and half the village, because she, by asking once, in the hunger, opened the pipe that connected her to the village forever, and never again ran dry. Do you see the difference? Two women of iron, two widows widowed young, and two entries. One with

three days in between and a smell through the wall. The other with people around the bed and a son sending money at Christmas. And the difference between the two, Soledade, all of it, was one door. Custódia never opened it. Felismina opened it once, in the hunger, and it stayed open the rest of her life."

And Soledade looked at the two entries side by side, Custódia's and Felismina's, and understood, with a clarity that pained her and that gave her hope at the same time, that she was still between the two, that she was not yet written, that her entry still had the lines blank, and that it was she, and only she, who was going to decide, in the years that remained to her, which of the two would be hers.

Soledade left the House of the Register with the truth of the cistern weighing on her and opening something in her. She crossed the square slowly, with her cane, with the papers in her hand, and stopped by the fountain, the fountain of Véspera, the one she had never used for having her own water. And a small thing happened, that on another day would have passed without leaving a mark and that on that one, with the Keeper still ringing within her, stayed with her. At the fountain was Mariana of the Reis line, filling her pitcher, and on seeing Soledade stand-

ing there, with her cane, a rare thing, the old woman of the heights by the fountain, she left her pitcher filling and came to her, and said, with the good simplicity of the women of the fountain:

"Oh Soledade, you here? What's this about that hip, woman, they've already told me you're limping." And without waiting for an answer, for Mariana was of those who do before they ask: "Look, if you like, I'll fill you a pitcher and send it up to you by my lad, that he goes up in the afternoon with the cattle and it's nothing to him."

And Soledade opened her mouth to say the usual, thank you, there's no need, I have my own water; and the phrase came to her mouth as it always came, ready, by heart. But that day, with the Keeper within, with the two entries still before her eyes, the phrase caught in her throat, and instead of it, for an instant, Soledade only stood looking at Mariana, looking at a woman who offered herself, at the fountain, with naturalness, without show, sending her a pitcher up by the lad who was going up anyway in the afternoon, and she understood that it was so, that it was exactly so that the water from outside entered a life, not by great gestures, but by a pitcher sent by a lad who was going

up anyway. And she did not say yes, for she was not yet ready, for fifty years are not undone in a square; but neither did she say the usual no. She said, with the embarrassed voice of one learning a new language, leave it for another time, Mariana, to-day I still manage; and Mariana said, all right, woman, whenever you want it's just to say so, and went back to her pitcher. And Soledade stayed there, and understood that the leave it for another time was not the usual never, that she had, for the first time, left a door ajar instead of shutting it for good, and that that leave it for another time was, for a cistern of fifty years, almost a revolution.

And she looked at the fountain, that time, not with the pride of one who does not need it, but with another thing, with a kind of new envy. Because the fountain was surrounded by people: people filling their pitchers, talking, crossing paths, helping one another set the pitcher on the head, and the water of the fountain ran, alive, shared, and never ran dry. And Soledade understood, looking at the fountain full of people and the house on the heights empty up there against the serra, that her whole life she had chosen the cistern out of pride; and that the fountain, which she had scorned for being of those who need, was after all the place of life, of the meeting, of the water that does not run dry

because it is shared. And that perhaps it was time, at last, to come down; not defeated, but human; and to put herself, she too, beside the fountain, among the people, to ask and to give, as those ask and give who do not want to run dry alone.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The pride of not needing



What Soledade still lacked, to be able to ask, was to dismantle the thing that most bound her, and it was not the fear of the closed door, for that she had already understood; it was the pride of not needing, which had grown over the fear and was harder to let go, because the fear gives pity and the pride gives pleasure, and one lets go more easily of what hurts us than of what flatters us.

Because Soledade, over fifty years, had turned the wound into a virtue. The child who had not asked out of fear of the door had become the woman who did not ask out of pride in not needing, and the pride was sweet, it was the thing the village praised in her. That one is made of iron. That one suffices to herself. That one owes nothing to anyone. And Soledade had built her whole identity on the not-needing: she was the one who governs her-

self alone, the independent one, the strong one; and that identity gave her a place, a dignity, a pride. To let it go, to ask, would be not only to overcome the old fear of the Fonsecas' door; it would be to come down from the pedestal of the I do not need, to admit that she needed like everyone, to cease to be the one of iron in order to be an old woman who asks for help. And that, to her pride, cost still more than the fear.

This was well seen one day, with Aurora. The neighbour, since the fall, had got into the habit of climbing up to the house on the heights now and then, with a pretext, a broth, some eggs, and stayed to help with what she saw was needed. And one day, seeing Soledade struggling with the wood, with her hip still bad, she said to her, simply:

"Oh Soledade, let me split that wood for you, woman. I still have a back, you're no longer fit for that."

And Soledade, instead of accepting the hand that fell to her from heaven, instead of saying ah yes, Aurora, how it would help me, thanked her with the usual firmness, no, thank you, I'll split it, I manage, and took up the axe, with effort, with her hip aching, and split the wood in front of Aurora, only so as not to let her split it. And Aurora shook her head, and went away, and

Soledade was left with the wood split and her pride intact and her hip worse; and that night, lying down, with her hip throbbing, she understood, for the first time with clarity, that she had refused a good thing, a friendly hand, a rest she needed, only out of pride, only so as not to be the one who needs, only to keep standing, before Aurora, the statue of the one who suffices to herself. And that that statue was costing her her hip, and her health, and perhaps her life; and that it was foolish, the statue.

And it went on showing itself, in those days, after the Keeper, that the pride was the last wall. Soledade already understood, with her head, that she ought to ask, that the cistern was running dry, that she had people wanting to enter. But at the hour of asking, of opening her mouth and saying help me, I need it, I cannot alone, there came the pride, the shame of showing herself in need, the horror of ceasing to be the one who does not need; and she fell silent, and said again all's well, and put it off. Because to ask was, to her pride, a defeat, a fall, a lowering; and she would sooner run dry standing than ask on her knees, which is the tragic reckoning of all cisterns, to prefer the dryness to the humiliation of needing.

And there was, in the digging at the pride, a memory that came to her and that made her blush alone in the dark, with shame, fifty years later. She remembered Felismina, the one of the house by the oven, of whom the Keeper would speak to her later without knowing that Soledade already knew her by name; she remembered, in her youth, having heard tell the story of Felismina who had come down to the fountain to beg help of the village in a winter of hunger, and having thought, with the disdain of her twenty years and of the cistern already made, I would sooner die than come down to the square to hold out my hand in front of everyone; I, if I were hungry, would tighten my belt and hold my tongue, I would not go crying my misery aloud. And she had thought herself, in thinking it, superior to Felismina, more dignified, more of iron; and she had judged the woman who had asked as a weak one, a shameless one, one with no self-respect. And now, fifty years later, lying in bed with her hip throbbing from having split the wood in front of Aurora only out of pride, Soledade understood that Felismina had been a thousand times wiser and braver than she; that to come down to the fountain in the hunger and ask in front of everyone, with the children to save, was a courage she, the one of iron, had never had; and that her old disdain for Felismina had been no

dignity at all, it had been only the blind pride of one who had not yet run dry enough to understand that to ask, sometimes, is the bravest thing there is.

And she understood, digging at the pride, a thing that shamed her and freed her. She understood that her pride of not needing had, beneath it, a contempt for those who need. She, in priding herself on sufficing to herself, thought herself, without saying it, superior to those who ask, who depend, who go to the fountain, who turn to others. She saw them, deep down, as weaker, and herself as stronger. And that hidden contempt for those who need was what kept her from joining them, from asking, from being one of them, because to ask was to come down to the level of those she secretly scorned. And on seeing this, Soledade was ashamed, because she understood that those who ask, who depend, who connect to one another, were not weaker than she; they were wiser, because they had understood what she had never understood, that people need one another, that there is no shame in it, that the shame is the pride that shuts itself and runs dry, and not the humility that asks and flourishes.

And she did, in those nights, the reckoning of what the pride had cost her, and it was a bitter reckoning. How many times, over fifty years, had they invited her, come to the feast, Soledade, come to the evening gathering, come with us to the fountain, come to the slaughter, and she had refused, no, thank you, I have things to do, I'll stay here.

She remembered one in particular, that came back to her in those nights with a sharpness that made her writhe in bed. Domingos was about ten, and it was the slaughter at the Reis house, down below, the house of Mariana's grandfather, and the whole village gathered, for the slaughter was one of the great feasts, two days of work and of food and of singing, with all the women around the tubs making the sausages and the men in the yard and the children among everyone's legs. And Mariana's mother, who was young like Soledade, had climbed up on purpose to the house on the heights, to invite her, come, Soledade, bring your boy, there are a lot of children there, and you come and give a hand with the sausages, for the hands are always too few, and one eats, and one sings, and you'll be with us, woman, don't stay up there alone on the heights. And Soledade, who wanted to go, whose body asked her to go, with Domingos tugging at her skirt wanting to go and see the other children, said

no. She said she had much to do, that she had the garden, that the boy had a cold, three excuses where one would have sufficed, which is how those lie who lie badly; and the truth is that she did not go, because to go to the slaughter was to go and give a hand and was to receive a portion of the meat at the end, as was given to all the women who helped, and to receive the portion of the meat was, at the bottom of her, to receive, was to owe, was to enter the reckoning of the give-and-take of the village, and Soledade kept no reckonings with anyone. And she stayed in the house on the heights, those two days, hearing, from up there, the singing rise from the Reis house, the laughter, the music, the whole village together making the slaughter; and Domingos, at the window, hearing it too, asking, Mother, why didn't we go?, and she answering, because we have things to do, son, and not knowing how to explain, even to herself, why they had things to do on an afternoon when the whole village was feasting. And they never gave her the portion of the meat, of course, because she had not helped; and she thought it was better so, that she owed nothing to anyone; and only now, in bed, fifty years later, did she understand that it was not the portion of the meat she had lost in those two days, it was the whole afternoon, it was the laughter, it was the hands of the other women

beside hers around the tub, it was a friendship with Mariana's mother that could have lasted a lifetime and that was never born because she stayed on the heights guarding the pride of owing a portion of meat to no one.

And each refusal had been not only a feast lost, but a bond not made, a friendship not born, an evening of company that did not happen, because to go to the feast was to be among people, and to be among people was, in a way, to depend, to need, and Soledade did not need. And by refusing the gatherings so as not to need, she had refused also the life that is made in them, and was left, at the end of fifty years, with the house on the heights full of water and empty of people, with the cistern full and the heart dry. The women of her age had friends of a lifetime, fellow godmothers, people to share old age with; and Soledade had no one, not because no one wanted her, but because she had never accepted an invitation, never come down to a feast, never let a bond be born, all out of pride of not needing, and the pride, in the end, had left her with an old age without comadres, alone on the heights, looking from afar at the fountain where the others gathered.

She had seen it well, without wanting to see it, at a funeral, not long since, in the village church. A woman of her age had died, Perpétua, and Soledade had gone to the Mass, for to Mass she went, though seldom, and had sat at the back, alone, as she always sat. And in front of her were the comadres of the dead woman, half a dozen old women who had been friends of Perpétua their whole lives, and who wept, but who wept together, leaning against one another, hand in hand on the pew, passing the handkerchief, supporting one another, and on leaving they stayed in the churchyard embraced, recalling the dead woman, laughing in the midst of the weeping at things they had done, the seven of them, when they were young. And Soledade, from the back pew, alone, looked at that, those old women weeping their friend together, supported, and felt a thing that shamed her for being so deep: she felt envy of the dead woman. Envy of a dead woman. Because Perpétua had died, but had died with six friends weeping her hand in hand, with a whole lifetime of comadres around the grave; and Soledade, alive, understood in that churchyard that if she died the next day there would not be six women weeping her hand in hand, there would be no comadres in the churchyard laughing at the pranks of when they were young, because she had never been young with

anyone, never given her hand to anyone on a church pew, never made her old age hand in hand with other old women; and that she was more alone, alive on the heights, than Perpétua, dead and buried with her six friends weeping her. And she had left the church before the end, out through that churchyard, alone, up the slope, with the envy of the dead woman weighing on her more than her hip, and had told no one, of course, for that was water for the cistern, still water, silent, one more.

And she understood more, and it was what lowered her pride for good: that her not-needing had never been true. She had always needed, like everyone, a hand, company, care, not to be alone. Only that, instead of admitting it and asking, she had hidden the need, feigned not to have it, and suffered it in silence, alone, without satisfying it. So that her pride of not needing had not made her not need; it had only made her need without ever being satisfied, to be hungry without ever eating, to be thirsty without ever drinking, to run dry of needs she had like everyone and that, out of pride, she had never let anyone meet. There was, therefore, no pride at all in her sufficing; there was only a life of denied needs, an old hunger of fifty years. And the pride, far from having made her strong, had made her hungry; far

from having made her independent, had made her run dry of things that were there, to hand, on the other side of the door she did not open.

And she decided, then, to begin to lower the pride, and it was one of the hardest things for her, because the pride was her skin of fifty years. She decided that she was going to try to ask, however small, however much it cost her, however much the pride cried out; and that, each time the all's well came, the I'll do it, the I don't need it, she would stop, and ask herself: am I saying this because it is true, or because my pride will not let me ask? Do I really need to do this alone, or am I running dry of pride while there are people wanting to help me? And it was so, with that question, that Soledade began to pierce the last wall, that of the pride, understanding that to ask was not to fall, it was to rise; it was to rise to the common humanity, to the fountain, to the vein that connects people. And that the true strength, the one she had never had, was not that of not needing anyone, which is the sad strength of cisterns; it was that of needing and having the courage to say it, which is the living strength of fountains. And that she, at sixty, was going, at last, to try to learn it.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Learning to ask



And Soledade began to learn to ask, and she learned it as one learns everything begun late, slowly, in pieces, with effort; and she began with the smallest, because to ask, for one who never asked, is done first in the tiny things, for the great ones come later, when the mouth has already unbent from so many years of saying I don't need it.

The first request was to Aurora, and it was a minuscule thing, and it cost her like the greatest. Instead of carrying alone a basket from the garden, as always, Soledade went down to the half-slope, and knocked at Aurora's door, with her heart leaping, with the pride crying out to her go back, do it yourself, don't ask, don't lower yourself. And when Aurora opened, Soledade almost

gave up, almost said it was only to say good day; but she breathed, and said, in a voice that trembled, the thing she never said:

"Oh Aurora. I needed a help. I can't manage the basket alone, because of my hip. Do you mind giving me a hand?"

And she stayed there, exposed, waiting, with the request in her mouth, like the child at the Fonsecas' door in the dark, with all the fear that Aurora would do what the door of childhood had done, that she would say no, that she would shut herself, that she would leave her outside.

And Aurora opened. Not the door, which was already open; she opened the yes. She laid down what she had in her hand, and said, of course, Soledade, why no, come, let's go, that's no weight for your hip; and she came, and helped, and did it with naturalness, with pleasure even, like one who is glad to be needed. And Soledade, on seeing Aurora say yes, on being helped in what she had asked, felt a thing that shook her to the bottom: she felt that the door had opened. Fifty years after the Fonsecas' door that did not open, she knocking at a door, asking, and the door opening. And it was so simple, and so enormous, and so contrary to what she had learned as a child, that Soledade had to hold her-

self not to weep there, in front of Aurora. Because she had just discovered, at sixty, the thing the Fonsecas' door had hidden from her for fifty: that doors open. That that one, the one of the frosty night, had been a bad door, one, a cruelty; but that most doors, when one knocks, open. And that she had spent fifty years not knocking at any because of one that had not opened, and had lost, in those fifty years, all the ones that would have opened.

And from that first request on, she ventured to more, slowly, and not all were easy, and not all came out well, because one who learns a language at sixty stumbles and mixes up the words. There was a request that cost her so much and that turned out in a way that taught her. She wanted to ask Mariana of the Reis line, at the fountain, that on her next trip to the larger town she bring her a remedy from the apothecary's, for she could no longer go and come in a day; and she went down to the square on purpose, and rehearsed the phrase along the way, and reached the fountain, and Mariana was there, and Soledade opened her mouth, and instead of asking, asked about the weather, and about Mariana's mother, and about everything but the remedy, because in the moment she could not, the phrase did not come out, the pride shut her mouth; and she went back

up the slope without having asked, with the remedy unfetched, furious with herself, realising that the old cistern still commanded more than she did. But on Sunday, at the fountain again, with more strength, she did it. Look, Mariana, I wanted to ask you a thing, if it's no trouble, it's that you go to the larger town on Thursday, don't you, and I needed a remedy from the apothecary's and I can't manage to go anymore; and Mariana said, well, that's no trouble at all, woman, give me the prescription and I'll bring it; and she brought it, and from then on always brought it, and it became a custom, and Soledade understood that the hard part had been only the first time, that afterwards the thing ran by itself, that a pipe, once opened, stays open and the water passes through it without being forced again.

She asked Aurora to take her, in Aurora's son's car, to a treatment in the larger town, and Aurora took her, glad, and they made the way talking, and it was the first time Soledade made that way with company instead of alone on the bus trembling; and halfway through she caught herself laughing at a thing Aurora was telling, and was struck by her own laughter, because it had been years since she had laughed with anyone inside a car, years since she had laughed with anyone anywhere, and she understood that this was what she had lost on all the ways she

had made alone on the bus trembling: not only the arm to support her, but the laughter, the talk, the company of making a journey with people. She asked, one day, the man who sold the firewood to split it for her and stack it, and paid him, and spared her hip; and on seeing the man split in half an hour, with knack and with strength, the wood that took her days and cost her her shoulder, she laughed again, at the absurdity of having spent years splitting with effort what another split in an instant, only for not wanting to ask, or to pay for, a thing so simple. And she went on discovering, request by request, a thing that turned her whole life inside out: that to ask, which she had feared as humiliation and as defeat, did not lower her in the eyes of the others; on the contrary, it drew her near to them. That people, far from scorning her for asking, liked to be asked, felt themselves useful, wanted, chosen, because to ask someone is to tell him I trust you, I need you, you are important to me; and that, Soledade discovered, is a gift, and not a weakness. And that she, by never asking, had not spared the others; she had deprived them of the joy of helping her, and had deprived herself of the water they would have given her.

And she connected, at last, the pipe to the fountain. She telephoned Domingos, one Sunday, and instead of the usual all's well, she said to him, in a trembling voice, the thing he had waited thirty years for.

"Son. All is not well." She heard herself say it, and it was like leaping from a high place. "I'm ill, and it's hard, and I'm tired of doing everything alone. The hip won't heal, and the house on the heights is big, and I can no longer manage. I would like... I would like you to come, son, if you could. These holidays. I need you."

And on the other end of the line there was a silence, and then Domingos's voice, choked, saying:

"Mother... of course I'll come. I'll come at once, I'll take leave and come at once." And, lower, almost weeping: "Why didn't you tell me sooner, Mother? For thirty years I've been waiting for you to ask me for something. Just one thing."

And Soledade, on hearing her son say I'll come at once, on feeling her son's door open wide at the first request in thirty years, understood the size of what she had lost by never asking, and the size of what she gained now by asking. Because she had just

recovered, with a single phrase, I need you, a son the all's well had kept outside her whole life. And she understood that to ask had not pushed her son away; it had joined them. That the phrase that had cost her most to say in sixty years had been also the one that brought her most love.

And when she hung up, she stayed seated on the stool by the dresser, with her hand still on the telephone in its cradle, and she trembled, trembled all over, as if she had made an enormous effort, and she had, it was the effort of raising a phrase of two kilos that weighed fifty years; and at the same time there was in her, beneath the trembling, a lightness she did not know, the lightness of one who has set down a weight she carried without knowing she carried it. And she caught herself laughing and weeping at the same time, alone in the kitchen, with the fire low, laughing at the absurdity of having taken thirty years to say to her son four words that after all came out so quickly, and weeping for all the Sundays on which she had not said them, for all the calls of two minutes with an all's well that had passed, one by one, like trains she had not boarded, watching them leave the station saying all's well, all's well, when what she wanted to cry out was stay, come, I need you. And she understood, on the stool by the dresser, that that phrase had not low-

ered her in her son's eyes, as the pride had promised her all her life it would lower her; it had, on the contrary, given her back to her son, given back to her son a mother he had lost thirty years before behind an all's well, and whom he had waited for, patient, on the other side of the world, every Sunday, to return.

And Domingos came. He took leave, and crossed the border, and climbed up to the house on the heights, and Soledade, at the door, on seeing her son climb the slope with his case in his hand, felt a thing she had not felt in years: she felt herself awaited, felt that someone was coming for her, felt what it is not to be alone. And Domingos embraced her at the door, and entered, and in a few days the house on the heights, which was the silence of a woman alone, filled with the voice of the son, with the steps of the son, with the noise of a house with people.

Domingos split all the wood, and it was watching him split the wood that most moved Soledade, without her quite knowing why. She stood at the kitchen window watching him, in the yard, setting the log on the block and raising the axe and letting it fall, the same gesture she had made for forty years alone, now made by a strong man who was her son, and there was in that, in the wood split by a son's hand while she watched from the window,

a thing so simple and so deep that it tightened her throat. Because all her life she had split the wood alone so as not to ask, and it had been enough to ask once for her son to split it gladly, and she there watching him, from the window, with her hands still for the first time in a winter, resting while another worked for her, and understanding that that rest, which she had feared her whole life as a weakness, was after all a sweetness, was the reward of one who had at last known how to ask. And Domingos, out there, feeling her at the window, turned and called to her, laughing, rest there, Mother, this is mine now, you've split wood enough for two lifetimes; and she laughed, from the window, and stayed watching him, and let herself stay, and did not go to help, and it was one of the hardest and sweetest things not to go to help, to stay at the window letting her son split her wood.

And he mended the roof, and took his mother to the doctors in the hired car, and they took their meals together. And at night, after supper, they sat by the hearth, and it was there, in the warmth of the fire, that the ice of thirty years of two-minute calls undid itself, slowly. At first they did not know how to talk to one another, for they had lost the knack, and they sat silent looking at the fire, and the silence was strange, it was the silence

of two who love each other and have unlearned how to converse. But one night Domingos began to speak of his father, of Alfredo, whom he had barely known, for he was a child when his father died at the quarry, and he asked his mother things he had never asked, what was he like, Mother, what did he like, tell me about him; and Soledade, at first with difficulty, for it was still water from very deep, went on telling him, told him his father's laugh, and the knack he had with the stone, and the way he picked him up as a small child; and Domingos listened, with his eyes on the fire, drinking in the words, because all his life he had wanted to know of that father and the mother had never spoken of him, for to speak of the dead man was to open the cistern and she did not open it. And they spoke, night after night, by the hearth, of the father, and of the old serra, and of the time when Domingos was small, and Soledade told him at last things he did not know of his own childhood, and Domingos told her of his life far away, of Idalina, of the grandchildren she barely knew, and they went on finding one another again by the hearth, mother and son, at the end of thirty years of all's well, because thirty years of two-minute calls with an all's well leave

no room to converse, and a hearth is needed, and time, and the open door, for a mother and a son to tell each other, at last, one to the other.

And one night, by the hearth, Domingos said to her, Mother, this is the first time in my life I feel I'm needed by you. You asked me to come, and I came, and I'm caring for you, and you know what? It does me good. All my life I wanted to be useful to you and you never let me. Thank you for letting me, this time. And Soledade, on hearing her son thank her for having let him help, understood the size of the turning: that by asking she had not given her son a weight, she had given him a gift, that of being needed by his mother, the thing he had waited his whole life for; and that her request, which had cost her so much, had been the best thing she had done for her son in thirty years.

And it was not all at once, and the pride still came to her, and there were still things she insisted on doing alone out of habit. But the pipe was open. Water from outside was coming into the cistern for the first time in fifty years. And Soledade, who was running dry, felt the level rise, not the water of the house, the other, the inner one, the one that comes from being cared for, from asking and being answered, from letting in those who love

us. And she understood that that water, the one from outside, the one she had refused her whole life out of pride and out of fear, was the one the cistern lacked so as not to run dry; and that there was, in receiving it, no defeat at all, there was only life, at last, running, connected to that of the others, as it should have run from the start, if a door, on a frosty night, fifty years ago, had not shut on a child in the dark.

CHAPTER NINE

The relapse



But one does not open a cistern of fifty years without its shutting again at the first thing, and Soledade had her relapse, and it came in the form the relapses of those who learned not to ask always come in: under cover of not wanting to be a burden, which is the fine excuse with which the old pride shuts itself again after a chink of opening.

It came after Domingos came and returned. The son came, in the holidays, and stayed a month, and cared for his mother, and took her to the doctors, and mended things about the house, and it was good, it was the best month Soledade had spent in years, with her son at home, with company, with the door open. But Domingos had his own life, on the other side of the world,

and had to return, and the moment he returned, and Soledade was again alone in the house on the heights, the old reflex returned, now dressed as delicacy.

She began to think that she had asked too much already. That she should not abuse Aurora, who already climbed the slope so many times. That she should not call the son again, who had already come, who she had already troubled enough, who had his own life to make and should not always be coming on his mother's account. That now she had to go back to doing things alone, so as not to be a burden. And behind the I don't want to abuse, which seemed consideration, was the retreat; was the pride shutting the pipe again, the cistern gathering itself again, the all's well returning to her mouth.

And there was a small sign, right at the start of the relapse, that showed the tide turning. Aurora climbed one late afternoon, as she had got into the habit of doing, with some fresh eggs in a cloth, and found the door of the house on the heights shut, a thing it had not been in the last weeks, for Soledade had taken to leaving it on the latch for her friend to enter; and she knocked, and Soledade came to open, and instead of making her enter as she did now, stayed at the door, in the doorway, re-

ceiving the eggs on the threshold, as Custódia received the bowls of broth from Aurora's mother, without letting her past the doorway. And Aurora noticed. Aurora, who of doors understood everything, noticed that the door had shut again, that there was again a threshold between her and her friend, that Soledade had received the eggs on the threshold and had not made her enter; and she said nothing that day, but she went down the slope with a tightening, because she knew that threshold, it was Custódia's threshold, it was the first brick going back to the wall.

And she went back to doing everything alone. She stopped asking Aurora, and when Aurora climbed and offered herself, she went back to the no, thank you, I manage. She stopped telling Domingos how she was, went back to the all's well, son. And on the Sunday calls, which had become long conversations in the month the son had come and just after, they went on shortening again, going back to the two-minute all's well, the door shutting also down the telephone line; and Domingos, who had tasted a month of a true mother, felt the difference, and asked, Mother, are you shutting yourself again?, and Soledade said, what an idea, son, all's well, and it was a lie, and the two of them knew it was, but the cistern already had more strength than the truth.

And in a short time she was shut again, running dry again, carrying alone again what she should share. And the worst is that she convinced herself it was kindness, that she was sparing the others, not weighing on them; when she was only retreating to the known wall, taking refuge in the I don't need it that was more comfortable to her than the new humility of asking.

And the body, again, warned her. On going back to doing everything alone, to forcing the hip, to carrying, her strength failed her again, and there was a bad day, and Soledade found herself again on the kitchen floor, alone, not calling, exactly as before. And it was Aurora, again, the one of the smoke, who found her, because one morning there was no smoke, and Aurora climbed, and came to her rescue. And this time, instead of only helping, she scolded, with the affection of one who scolds because she cares.

"Oh Soledade, well? Again?" said Aurora, lifting her from the floor. "You learned to ask, you were asking, your son was here, you were better, and now you've shut yourself again, gone back to the all's well, gone back to falling alone. Why, woman?"

And Soledade, ashamed, on the floor, said the truth:

"I didn't want to abuse it. I'd already asked you so much, I'd already called my son, I thought I shouldn't trouble you again."

And Aurora, on hearing the I didn't want to abuse it, shook her head, and said to her, sitting her in the chair, the thing that made her stay:

"Soledade, to abuse is to ask for what one doesn't need, or to ask only of one until you wear him out. To ask for what one needs, shared among those who love us, is not to abuse, it's to live. You don't abuse me by asking me a help now and then, as I don't abuse you if one day I need it and ask you, which I shall, for I'm old too. That's how people live, asking and giving, by turns. What's not living is what you were doing, running dry alone on the floor so as not to trouble anyone. That's not not abusing, woman. That's pride by another name."

And Aurora, boiling the milk on the fire while she spoke, turned with the spoon in her hand and said still more, from deep down, because she was angry and the anger was love. Do you know what costs me, Soledade? It's not climbing the slope, that I do with my eyes shut. What costs me is to look up from below, in the morning, and see your smoke, and be left with my heart in my hands not knowing whether the smoke means you're well or

that you're still keeping on your feet pretending you're well. You took from me the rest of the smoke, woman. Before, I saw the smoke and was at ease. Now I see the smoke and think, has she fallen again and still had the strength to light the fire before she had no strength for anything more? This is what you did to me with your I don't want to abuse: now not even the smoke sets me at ease, because I know you're capable of dying with the fire lit only so that I should notice nothing. And Soledade, on hearing that, was left without air, because she had never thought that her shutting herself hurt not only her, it hurt Aurora too, took from Aurora the rest of the smoke, made of her friend's watch a torment instead of an ease; and she understood that her cistern did not run dry only herself, it ran dry also those who loved her, who stayed outside watching her run dry without being able to pour her a drop, and that this, to make those who loved her suffer with her stubbornness of not asking, was perhaps the deepest cruelty of the cistern, the one she had never seen.

And Soledade, on hearing pride by another name, and on hearing what she had taken from Aurora, understood that Aurora was right; that the I don't want to abuse was the disguised pride, the old cistern shutting itself with a pretty excuse. And she understood a deep thing about learning to ask: that it was not a

thing one learns once and it stays. That it was a thing one has to learn again every day, against the habit of fifty years, which always returns, at the first respite, to shut the pipe. And that what mattered was not never to relapse, for that was impossible; it was to recognise the relapse when it came, dressed as not abusing, as all's well, as I'll do it, and to open the pipe again, to ask, to let in again.

And there happened, in those days, a thing that helped Soledade to understand, in a way no word had made her understand, what the giving and the receiving by turns was. Aurora, who was always climbing the slope to come to her rescue, fell ill herself, with a strong flu, of the kind that lays a person in bed with fever; and Soledade knew it, because one day she did not see Aurora at her window down below, and found it strange, for she was growing used to counting Aurora as Aurora counted her. And Soledade did a thing that astonished her herself: she went down to the half-slope, with her cane, with effort, with a broth in a pot covered with a cloth, and knocked at Aurora's door, and entered, and saw to her friend, sat at the edge of Aurora's bed giving her the broth by the spoonful, putting cold cloths on her forehead, doing for her what Aurora had done for her so many times. And Aurora, weak, with the fever, let herself be cared for,

without saying no, thank you, I manage, let Soledade give her the broth by the spoonful like one who receives the most natural thing in the world; and she said only, halfway through, in a hoarse voice, with a faint smile, you see, Soledade, this is how it is, today I'm the one needing and you the one rescuing, tomorrow it's the other way round again, and that's how people live, by turns. There's no shame at all in this, woman. And Soledade, on giving the broth to her sick friend, on being, for the first time, the one who rescues instead of the one rescued, understood a new thing, which was the other side of receiving: that to give was also good, that it did one good to be the one who comes, to be needed, to have a broth to give to one who needed it; and she understood that it was exactly this joy of giving that she had taken from Aurora, from Domingos, from the whole village, each time she refused to be helped, that by not letting them give her anything she had deprived them of this sweetness she herself felt now, at the edge of her friend's bed, with the spoon in her hand.

And she went back to asking, of Aurora, of the son, and this time with the awareness that she was going to have to do it always, that the cistern was always wanting to shut itself, and that to live connected to the fountain was a work of every day, and not a

victory of one time. And she understood that to have at her side one who would scold her, who would tell her Soledade, you've shut yourself again, was the difference between running dry alone and being pulled back to the water each time she retreated. And that it was that, that of having one who calls us back to the fountain, the greatest gift of having, at last, let someone in: because a person alone relapses and stays fallen, and a person connected relapses and is lifted up.

CHAPTER TEN

At the foot of the stairs



And the day came of the greatest trial, the scene the whole book walked towards, small and enormous: Soledade at the foot of another house's stairs, knocking at a door, asking, by her own choice, before despair, and bearing the hardest thing of all for a cistern, which is not to knock, it is to stay and bear the door's opening.

It was so. There was a winter night, cold, on which Soledade, alone in the house on the heights, felt unwell. Not fallen yet, not in despair yet; but with a tightening in her chest that she knew, that of the old fright, the pain rising up her arm, the cold sweat, the heart beating out of time. And she understood that she was going to need help, and she had, at that moment, the choice the book had been preparing for her. Either she waited, as always, for it to pass, or to worsen, or for them to find her fallen in the

morning with no smoke in the chimney, which is to ask late, out of despair, without choice. Or she went down, now, on her own legs, while she still could, and went to knock at a door, and asked, by her decision, before falling; which is to ask early, by choice, with dignity.

And Soledade, for the first time in her life, chose the second. She put her coat on over her nightdress, put on her shoes, took the lantern and the cane, and went down, in the dark, down the mountain, to Aurora's house, on the half-slope, to ask for help. Exactly as the child of fifty years ago had gone down in the dark to ask for help at the house of the FONSECAS; but now by choice and not by order, now old and not a girl, now deciding to go down instead of waiting for the misfortune.

And the descent was the whole book made path. Because while she went down, in the dark, with the lantern trembling in her hand, with her hip aching and her chest tightening, to knock at the door of another house to ask, Soledade was reliving the night of childhood, the other descent in the dark, the other going to ask for help. The way was the same as always, the track she had gone down a thousand times with an empty pitcher, but by night and with that chest tightening it was another way,

longer, more treacherous, with each stone wanting to make her fall. She passed by the bend of the fig tree, and by the great stone they called the seat, where as a child she used to sit to rest, and the lantern went on opening a circle of light on the frosted ground before her feet, and she set the cane, and the foot, and the cane, and the foot, slowly, with her heart hammering not only from the effort, from the fear. And she reached the bend of the path, the one from which all her life she had looked at the fountain below full of people, the spot from which she watched the others fill their pitchers without ever going down to join them; and she stopped there an instant, panting, and looked down, and the fountain was dark and empty at that hour of the night, with no one, and the square slept, and only Aurora's house, on the half-slope, had down there, behind a window, a shred of light of one not yet gone to bed. And it was towards that shred of light that Soledade went down, from the bend where she had always looked from afar, going down at last the way she had never gone down to ask, the old woman making, at sixty, the descent the girl had made at eight, but now the other way round, now by choice, now to a door she had chosen for knowing that it opened.

And she went with all the fear of that night rising through her body, the fear of the door that does not open, of the light that goes out, of the voices that drop. Each step down the mountain was a step against fifty years of not asking, was the child and the old woman going down together the same mountain, one trembling for the other. And there was, in each metre, the temptation to turn back, to climb, not to ask, to bear it alone as always, not to risk the closed door again. There was a moment, halfway, in which the pain in her chest eased a little, and the old cistern took advantage of the respite to whisper in her ear the usual, you see, it's passing already, you don't need to trouble anyone at this hour, climb, go to bed, tomorrow you'll be well; and Soledade stopped, and almost heard it, almost turned round, because it was so easy to turn round, it was the way of fifty years, it was to climb and shut the door and say all's well. But she remembered the Keeper, the two entries, Custódia's and Felismina's, and she remembered that to ask early, by choice, with the pain easing, was exactly the courage the book had asked of her, and that to wait for the pain to return and lay her down was to ask late, was Custódia, was the three days; and she did not turn round. She went on going down, against the whisper, and it was that, to go down with the pain easing and not

with the pain killing, the true choice, because it is easy to ask when there is no remedy left, and the hard thing, the one she did there, was to ask when it still seemed she could bear up. She went down, because she had now, against the fear and against the whisper, all she had learned: Aurora, the son, the Keeper, Mariana at the fountain, the doors that had opened. And she went down to the foot of the stairs of Aurora's house, and stopped before the door, and it was there that the greatest battle was fought.

Because to knock was hard, but to knock Soledade could still do; the hardest, the thing the Fonsecas' door had made almost impossible for her, was what came after knocking: it was to wait. It was to stay there, at the foot of the stairs, with the request made, exposed, at the mercy, waiting for the door to open, without knowing whether it would open, reliving, in that wait, the wait of the child at the door in the dark that did not open. And it was that wait, and not the knocking, the greatest trial, because in the wait was all the fear, that of having asked and possibly not being opened to, that of having exposed herself for nothing, that of the door, like the Fonsecas', falling silent and leaving her outside, and the light going out.

Soledade knocked. And waited. And her heart beat like the child's of fifty years ago, and each second of closed door was fifty years weighing on her, and she wanted to flee, wanted to climb the mountain before knowing, so as not to risk the closed door, so as not to relive the light that goes out. But she bore it. She stayed. She bore the door's opening, which is the greatest courage of a cistern, to stay at the foot of the stairs bearing the terrible time between knocking and being opened to, without fleeing, trusting, against fifty years of proof to the contrary, that this time the door would open.

And the door opened.

The light came on, inside. Footsteps were heard. And the door opened, and on the other side was Aurora, in her nightgown, with the face of sleep and the concern of one woken in the middle of the night; and on seeing Soledade there, at the foot of the stairs, in the cold, with her cane, unwell, in need, Aurora did what the Fonsecas' door had not done. She took her in.

"Soledade! What's wrong, woman? Come, come inside, come, let me help you, come in, it's cold."

And she took her by the arm, and pulled her into the house, into the warmth, and sat her down, and wrapped her warm, and went at once to telephone to send for help, and stayed with her.

And Soledade, on hearing the come inside, on seeing the door open wide, on being pulled into a warm house instead of left in the dark at the closed door, felt undone within her, all at once, the night of fifty years ago. Because the door had opened. The door, that time, had opened. And the child who had stayed at the Fonsecas' door in the dark, and who still lived within Soledade, on the inside of that door of fifty years ago, was at last taken in, fifty years later, by a door that opened; and she understood, the child and the old woman together, seated in the warmth in Aurora's kitchen, that after all the world was not the Fonsecas' door, that there were doors that open, that one knocks and they open, that one asks and they come to the rescue. And that she could, at last, stop living behind the closed door of childhood, because she had just knocked at another, and borne it, and seen it open, and entered, and been pulled into the warmth by a hand that did not leave her in the dark.

And that night, the fright passed, with the help on its way and Aurora making her a hot tea in the kitchen, Soledade did a thing she had not done in fifty years: she told. They were the two of them at the table of Aurora's kitchen, in the quiet that comes after a distress has passed, with the clock striking in the silence and the tea steaming in the cups, and Aurora asked nothing, for she was of those who know that things are told when they want to come out, and it was that silence without questions that let Soledade open her mouth. She began slowly, looking at the tea, you know, Aurora, I never told this to anyone, and she stopped, and Aurora said nothing, only laid her hand on the table next to hers, and waited. And Soledade told.

She told Aurora the night of the Fonsecas' door. The father burning with fever, the mother distressed sending her down, the cutting cold, the frost on the path, the knees skinned in the fall, the great house with its windows lit, the knocking at the door, the calling, ho there, the house, Senhor Fonseca, my father is dying; and the voices inside, and the scraping of the chair, and then the light of the entrance going out slowly through the crack of the door, and the house making itself empty, deaf, with the child in the dark knocking and calling and no one opening. She told it softly, slowly, with her voice trembling, and halfway

she had to stop, for the tears would not let her, and Aurora squeezed her hand and said only, weep, woman, weep, it was time, and Soledade wept, and went on, the story she had kept at the bottom of the cistern fifty years, that she had never told her mother, nor her son, nor anyone. And she told it to the end, told the climb in the dark with skinned knees and the help unfetched, told the lie to her mother, they weren't there, Mother, the house was all dark, told the decision she had taken climbing the mountain, never again do I ask anyone; and on reaching the end, on saying and I never asked again, Aurora, fifty years, and look where that brought me, this night, to the foot of your stairs, she was left exhausted, emptied, like one who has at last poured out a whole cistern of rotten water. And Aurora heard her, without interrupting her, and at the end took her by the hand, and said only, with a whole serra of pain in her voice, ai Soledade, and you carrying that alone for fifty years, and never telling anyone. Those FONSECAS, God forgive them, did you a harm that lasted a lifetime. And Soledade, on telling at last the shame she had kept half a century, on being heard, on having her hand held by another hand, felt a thing she had never felt: she felt the old water, still, rotten, from the bottom of the cistern, begin to drain away and be replaced by new water; because a pain told is

a pain that begins to heal, and a pain kept silent fifty years is a still water that rots the whole cistern, and Soledade, on telling the night of the door, on letting it come out at last from her mouth to a friend's ears, emptied a little of the rotten water that had poisoned her life, and let in, in its place, the clean water of being, for the first time, heard.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The water from outside



After the door that opened, Soledade entered a new time, that of letting in the water from outside not only in emergencies, but every day; and it was the sweetest crossing of the book and the strangest for her, because a cistern that opens discovers that to receive, which she feared, is one of the warmest things there are.

She began to let herself be cared for, and went on learning, slowly, that to receive had a taste. She let Aurora enter more into her life, climb up and down the slope, share the chores, stay and talk by the hearth at the end of the day. She let Domingos call and ask in earnest, and she answered in earnest, told how she was, asked when she needed; and the Sunday calls, which before were a two-minute all's well, became long conversations, of a mother and a son who tell each other one to the other. And

the house on the heights, which had always been a shut fortress, went on becoming a house where people entered, where there was talk, company, water from outside; and that open house was infinitely better than the fortress, because in the fortress Soledade was safe and alone, and in the open house she was accompanied, and the company, she discovered, was well worth the risk of no longer being so safe, of depending a little now, of no longer being made of iron.

And she understood a deep thing about receiving, that answered her whole life as a cistern. It is that she had always seen giving and receiving as unequal things, giving as worthy and receiving as low, and so had only wanted to give, or rather, not even to give, to suffice to herself, not to need to receive from anyone. And she discovered, on letting herself be cared for, that receiving, far from being low, was a form of giving; because one who receives gives the other the joy of giving, and that a person who only gives and never receives is not generous, she is proud, because she robs others of the giving. And that the true sharing, the one that fills the fountain and lets no one run dry, is that of giving and receiving by turns, in which now one is a fountain for the other, now one lets the other be a fountain for oneself; and

that she, by only wanting to give and never receive, had cut half the sharing, the half of receiving, and had run dry of that half she had denied.

And the house on the heights, which for fifty years had heard only Soledade's voice when she talked alone with the hens, gained an evening gathering. Aurora climbed, at the end of the day, two, three times a week, and the two of them sat by the hearth, each with her sewing or her knitting, talking, or not even that, sometimes only silent watching the fire, for there is a company that needs no words and that Soledade had never known, that of being silent beside someone without the silence weighing. And Aurora brought her news of the village, that Soledade of the heights had never known of anyone and that she now knew, who had married, who had fallen ill, who had had a child, the life of the village coming into her house by Aurora's mouth as the water from outside came into the cistern by the new pipe. And one night Aurora, knitting, said to her, you know, Soledade, it's years since I had a comadre. I live alone, my own have all gone, and I watched the smokes of the houses every morning and had no one to say good night to. And now I have you, up here, and I climb, and we're the two of us, and it does me good, woman. You think it's I who do you the charity of climbing, and

it isn't, you fool; it's I who needed you as much as you needed me. And Soledade, on hearing that, understood one more thing of the reverse of her life as a cistern: that she, by letting herself at last be helped, was not only receiving, she was giving Aurora a comadre that Aurora too did not have; that her asking had not been an alms Aurora did her, it had been a door that opened for the two of them, and that on the other side of her solitude there had been, all those years, Aurora's solitude, and that it had been enough to open one door for the two solitudes to keep each other company.

And there was a new joy in Soledade's life, the joy of the small dependences. She discovered that it was good to have someone bring her a thing from the village, instead of always going herself, with her cane, down the slope. That it was good to have someone take her by car, instead of always catching the bus alone. That it was good to have someone ask how she was and to whom she could tell the truth. And each of these small dependences, which she had feared as defeats, revealed itself a sweetness, a bond, a thread of water from outside entering the cistern and turning it, from a still pool, into a connected, living tank. And Soledade, who had lived fifty years proud of not de-

pending on anyone, discovered at sixty the sweetness of depending a little, of not being made of iron, of being, at last, human, connected, needed and cared for, like everyone.

And she connected to the fountain for good. She began to come down to the square, to the fountain of the village, not for needing the water, for she had her cistern, but for needing the people, the meeting, the talk made around the water. She carried a pitcher, though she had no need to fill it, carried it for the carrying, for having an excuse, for she was still of the time when one needed an excuse to go and be with people; and she filled it at the fountain, beside the others, and stayed, and listened, and at first only listened, silent, for she did not know how to enter the conversations of the women, never having learned, but she went on learning, went on putting in a word, went on laughing at what they laughed at, went on making herself, slowly, one of the women of the fountain.

And there was a morning, after some weeks of coming down, on which a small thing happened that for Soledade was worth more than many great ones. She was at the fountain, with the pitcher full, and had to carry it, and her hip would not let her set it on her head, and she was going to take it to carry it in her

arms, with effort, when Mariana of the Reis line, who was beside her, said, wait, woman, give it here and I'll set it on your head, come, bend down a little; and she coiled the roll of cloth on her crown, with that old knack, and balanced the pitcher on top of it, and said, now straighten up slowly, and let go, let go, for it won't fall; and Soledade, for the first time in her life, straightened up with the water on her head, and Mariana let go, and the pitcher stayed, balanced, and Soledade stood there an instant not daring to move, with the water on her head and her hands trembling at her sides, and Mariana laughing, you see, it's straight, you can walk; and Soledade took a few steps, with the pitcher on her head, among the women of the fountain, and it was a gesture she had seen made her whole life from the bend of the path, from up there, from afar, to the others, to Mariana setting the pitcher on old Encarnação's head, and that no one had ever set for her, because she had never come down, never asked, never let; and now, at sixty, with her bad hip and the water trembling on her head and the laughter of the women around her, she did it at last, was at last one of the women of the fountain, with the pitcher on her head set by another's hands, and she had to blink so that the water that came to her should not be the water of the pitcher.

And the fountain, which she had scorned her whole life for being of those who need, became the place where she went to be with people, where she crossed paths, where she belonged. The women of the village, who had always seen her from afar, the old woman of the heights, the one of iron, the one who does not come down, began to see her in the square, at the fountain, talking, and found it strange, and liked it, and made room for her. Old Encarnação, who was of the oldest, said to her one day, without roundabouts, as the very old say, so you had a voice all along, woman, I thought you were mute, fifty years watching you pass up there without giving good day to anyone; and Soledade laughed, and said, I had a voice, Encarnação, I had it kept away, it's that no one asked it of me; and Encarnação said, well now give it, for a new voice is wanted here at the fountain. And the house on the heights, which had been her solitary fortress, became only where she slept, because life, now, she made down below, at the fountain, among the people, connected, as the Keeper had told her the fountains did and not the cisterns.

And Soledade understood that she had not lost her water by coming down to the fountain; she had gained that of the others. That a cistern that connects to the fountain does not become

poorer, it becomes richer, because it comes to have its own water and that of everyone, and never runs dry again, because the fountain, the vein that connects people, never runs dry, runs always, alive, shared, and whoever connects to it drinks of it forever. And she understood, at last, what the Keeper had taught her: that people are not made to be cisterns, shut, sufficing to themselves, running dry alone; they are made to be fountains, connected to one another, giving and receiving, asking and rescuing. And that she, by opening the pipe, by letting in the water from outside, by connecting to the fountain, had not lost her independence; she had traded a proud solitude for a living belonging. And that that trade, which her pride of fifty years had painted to her as a defeat, was after all the greatest victory of her life: that of having learned, before the end, before running dry, to ask, and to receive, and to let, at last, the water from outside, the water of those who loved her, come into her cistern and make of it, from a shut pool on the verge of running dry, a tank connected to the fountain of the village, full, shared, alive.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Asking before despair



And the day came on which Soledade understood, with her whole body, that she had learned to ask; and it was in a small gesture, as the climaxes of *Véspera* are, and it was a gesture that fifty years before would have been impossible to her: she asked for a thing she did not need with any urgency, only because, only because the company was good, and she understood, in that light request, that she was healed.

Because there is a difference between asking in despair and asking before despair, and that difference was the whole crossing. To ask in despair, fallen on the floor, without choice, anyone does, because despair compels. But to ask before, by choice, when one could still bear up alone, when the pride still served to do it oneself, that was the victory; because it is to ask not for having no other remedy, but for having understood that the

connected life is better than the life alone, even if alone one would bear up. And Soledade reached there. One Saturday, instead of spending the afternoon alone in the house on the heights, she telephoned Aurora and said, oh Aurora, come and have a coffee with me, I felt like company; and there was no need, she could have made the coffee alone and drunk it alone as she had done fifty years, but she preferred the company, and asked for it, for pleasure and not for need. And it was in that light request, without despair, by preference and not out of distress, that Soledade knew the cistern had opened for good.

And there was a day that sealed the cure, and it was when another person asked of her. There had come to live, not long since, in the house that stood empty next to Aurora's, a young couple, from the larger town, people of the city who had wearied of the city, and the woman was called Benedita, and she was alone all the week because her husband worked away and only came at weekends, and she had a child of two, and knew no one on the serra, and had that lost air of one who has come from far and does not yet know whom to attach herself to. Soledade had noticed her at the fountain, silent in a corner, not daring to enter the conversations, as she herself had done at the start; and she had recognised her, recognised in Benedita the

woman from outside who does not know how to ask, not out of pride like her, but out of shame at being new, at being a stranger, at not yet having the right; and she had wanted to say something to her, and had not said it, for she was still learning to speak to people.

And it was that Benedita who knocked at her door, one winter night, in the dark, with the child in her arms burning with fever, weeping with distress, because the child was ill and she had no car, for the husband had taken it, and she did not know whom to turn to, and had seen, from below, that in the house on the heights there was still a light, and had climbed with effort in the dark with the child in her arms to knock at the door of an old woman she barely knew, exactly as Soledade had done, as the child had done at the Fonsecas' door, in the same dark, on the same serra, with the same fear that the door would not open.

And Soledade, on hearing the knock at her door at that hour, on hearing, from outside, in the dark, a distressed voice calling, ho there, the house, oh Senhora Soledade, please, my child has a high fever, I beg you for the love of God, understood, with a shiver that ran through her whole body, that she had, at that instant, in her hands, the door of her childhood. It was the same

scene, in reverse. It was she, now, on the inside of the door, with the light lit, with people outside in the dark begging help for a child. It was she, now, the Fonsecas. She could be the door that does not open, she could lower the light, she could make herself deaf, she could do to that woman and that child exactly what the Fonsecas had done to her and her father fifty years before. Or she could be the door that opens, she could give Benedita and the child what the Fonsecas' door had denied her.

And Soledade did not hesitate an instant. She opened the door wide, at night, in the cold, and the light of the kitchen fell upon Benedita and the child in the dark of the porch, and Soledade pulled them inside, come, my girl, come in, come in quickly with the child, come into the warmth, let me see, what's wrong with him, give him here, sit down; and she took the child from her arms, and put her hand on his forehead, and gauged his fever, and knew what to do, for she had raised a son alone on the serra and knew the fevers of children, and undressed the child, and put cloths of warm water on him, and made him a tea of things from the garden, and bade Benedita be calm, this will come down, woman, don't be frightened, I've been through this with mine, and sat the woman by the hearth, and stayed with her, and halfway through sent word to Aurora by the arrangement

of signs they had, and Aurora climbed, and brought down her son with the car, and they took the child to the larger town, and the child got well, for it was only one of the fevers children catch, but that to a mother alone and from outside, in the dark of the serra, seems the end of the world.

And by opening her door to one who asked, by being, for another in the dark, the door that opens, Soledade closed the circle of the book, and healed the night of childhood at the root. Because the deepest way to heal a door that did not open to us is to become, ourselves, a door that opens; and Soledade became, on that night, the door she had waited for, in vain, at the age of eight, at the Fonsecas' door; and by being it for another, she was it, retroactively, for the child she still was, within her, on the inside of that door of fifty years ago. And there was more, and it was what moved her to the bottom: days later, the child recovered, Benedita climbed up to the house on the heights with a bunch of wildflowers and her eyes brimming, to thank her, and said to her, you don't know what you did for me that night, I was so alone, so lost, knowing no one, and you opened your door to me; and Soledade, on hearing that, had to sit down, because it was her own voice of fifty years ago speaking to her through Benedita's mouth, it was the child of the Fonsecas' door saying

at last, by another mouth, at a door that opened, what she had never been able to say at the one that did not open. And she took Benedita's hand, and said to her, oh my girl, you are not alone, do you hear? You have me now up here, and you have Aurora down below, and you have the fountain, and the village. When you need anything, whatever the hour, you knock at this door, that this door opens. This door always opens. Do you hear? And one understands, reading the book, that in saying to Benedita this door always opens, Soledade was saying it also to the girl she had been, and closing, with that phrase, the door that had stayed open, bleeding, fifty years.

And at that point, Soledade did the sum of the whole crossing, and understood what she had learned, that turned inside out the name they had given her. She had learned that to suffice to oneself is not not to need, it is not to let in. That the cistern that prides itself on not coming down to the fountain is the one that runs dry in the great drought. That to ask is not to come down defeated, it is to connect our water to that of the others so that none runs dry alone. That to receive is a form of giving, because it gives the other the joy of helping. And that the door that did not open, in childhood, had been one, a misfortune, and not the

law of the world; that most doors open, and that she had lost fifty years behind a closed door for not having the courage to knock at the ones that would open.

And she understood that her name, Soledade, solitude, which she had fulfilled her whole life by making herself a shut cistern, could now be fulfilled the other way round. It could be the name of one who knew solitude and overcame it, of one who came out of it, of one who, having been the most alone, learned, before the end, to connect; and made of solitude not a destiny, but a crossing, with another shore, that of the people.

And there was a Sunday, about that time, on which she saw, in a single day, all that she had traded. In the morning she went down to the fountain, and Mariana set the pitcher on her head, and Encarnação called her the new voice of the fountain, and she stayed in the square talking with the women an hour that before she would have spent alone on the heights. In the afternoon Aurora climbed, and they sat by the hearth knitting and talking of the village. At the end of the afternoon the telephone rang, and it was Domingos, and instead of the two-minute all's well it was a long conversation, with Idalina in the background sending kisses and the grandchildren wanting to speak to their

grandmother, and Soledade spoke with the grandchildren, whom she barely knew, and promised them that next year she would go and see them, a thing fifty years of cistern had never let her promise. And at night, as she was going to bed, Benedita knocked at her door, only to bring her a sweet she had made and to tell her the child was well; and Soledade made her enter, and the two of them had a tea, and Benedita went away, and the house on the heights was left, for an instant, with the smell of one who had passed through it, with the warmth of one who had been there. And Soledade, alone at last, but of a new solitude, that of one who is left alone after having been with people, which has nothing to do with the other, that of one who is always alone, went to bed and thought that in a single Sunday she had received more water from outside than in fifty years of shut cistern; and that the house on the heights, the same house, with the same cistern, was now another house, because through it people passed, people came in and went out, and a house through which people pass, she understood, is not a house alone, even if it stays up on the heights of the serra, far from the fountain, with its own water.

And she looked at the life left to her: the house on the heights now open, with Aurora going up and down, Domingos coming in the holidays and calling in earnest, the fountain down below full of people who were hers, the new neighbour to whom she had opened the door. And she looked at it without the pride that had run her dry and without the fear that had shut her, with the new lightness of one who no longer has to bear everything alone. And she felt, for the first time in sixty years, the thing the cistern lacked and the fountain has: she felt the water running, alive, connected, shared, coming in and going out, giving and receiving. And she understood that she was no longer running dry, that she was full, not of her own water alone, of everyone's, and that it was that, the shared water, the only one that never runs dry. And she understood that to learn to ask, at sixty, after fifty of not asking, had been the hardest and most important thing of her life, because it had been to learn, at last, not to die alone, and to let, before the end, the water from outside, the water of those who loved her, come into her cistern and save her from the dryness that pride and fear had prepared for her.

From the register of Véspera

And of everything a record was made.

Be it set down that Soledade, of the Highlanders, of the house on the heights with its own cistern, who did everything alone and always and never asked anything of anyone, learned, at sixty, the hardest thing for one who shut herself into a cistern: to knock at a door and to ask, before despair, and to bear the door's opening. Be it set down that she went down, one night, to the foot of another house's stairs, and knocked, and waited, and the door opened, and she entered, and that on entering she was healed of the other door, that of childhood, which had not opened to a child in the dark and which had made her a cistern for fifty years.

The register keeps the houses and what each one gathers, and there are houses of cistern, that have their own water and do not come down to the fountain, and that are the first to run dry in the great droughts. This Keeper saw, in the book, the house on the heights of Soledade set down as a house of its own cistern, and saw the woman be, herself, a cistern, shut, sufficing to herself, running dry alone; and saw, afterwards, a pipe open in her, water from outside come into her, connect to the fountain, and her entry change its character, cease to be that of one who runs dry apart and become that of one who connected herself, at last, to the vein that connects people. And the Keeper understood that Soledade had fulfilled the name the opposite way:

*she was called solitude, and made of solitude not a destiny, but a crossing,
with another shore, that of the people.*

*Whoever reads this entry and recognises herself in some Soledade who
never asks, who does everything alone out of pride and out of wound, who
answers all is well when it is not, who would sooner run dry than depend, let
her know what she learned and what this house records: that to suffice to
oneself is not not to need, it is not to let anyone in; that the cistern that never
receives water from outside, in a dry summer, runs dry; that to ask is not a
defeat, it is a gift one gives to those who love us, because those who love us
want to help; and that the greater courage, for one who shut herself a whole
life, is not to bear up more alone, it is to come down from the house on the
heights, and to knock at a door, and to ask before despair, and to bear the
hardest thing of all, which is that the door should open, and to discover, with
astonishment, that doors open, that the one that did not open was one, and
that on the other side of those that open there are people who had waited, for
years, for us to knock.*

*Soledade traded the cistern for the fountain, the pride of not needing for the
sweetness of asking, the shut fortress where she ran dry for the open house
where water comes in from outside. And in the houses of Véspera, since that
night on which she went down to the foot of some stairs and knocked and the
door opened, there is one more woman who no longer confuses sufficing to
herself with living, because she learned that the water that does not run dry
is the shared one, and that to ask is to open the pipe that connects our
cistern to the fountain of everyone, and that no one, connected to the
fountain, runs dry alone.*

*And of everything a record was made, by the hand of the Keeper, in the
register of Véspera.*



For the reader

Thank you for crossing this year of Véspera with Soledade. If the story touched you, pass it on, not as proof, but as seed.

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